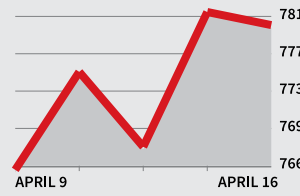


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77988.68 (-122.56)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24196.75	-34.55
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.43	-0.03
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.19	-0.18
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	152493.00	+240
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	251292.00	+2273

INDIA DRIVE.

Renault aims to make India one of its top three global markets by 2030 with speedier launches, says Global CEO Francois Provost **p2**



POLLSCAPE.

In Avinashi Assembly constituency, established BJP leader faces young challengers in a tight contest **p8**

Auto industry, govt agree on draft CAFE-3 norms; nudge for E25 fuel vehicles

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi



In a significant development, the automobile industry has reached a consensus on the draft Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE-3) norms, stating that the current version released on April 8 should remain unchanged without further additions.

This was conveyed at a meeting on Thursday between the industry and Secretaries of the Ministries of Power, and Road Transport and Highways, as also the Additional Secretary, Ministry of Heavy Industries. At the meeting, the government proposed introducing an E25 fuel mixture in the near future, advising the industry to begin preparations immediately, according to sources.

EMISSION REDUCTION

What the industry has agreed to are draft CAFE-3 norms, effective from April 2027 to 2032, that shift India's regulatory focus towards total fleet emission reductions rather than vehicle size.

To reach net-zero goals, the framework introduces a market-based credit trading system, besides incentivising

the shift to electric, hybrid and flex-fuel vehicles.

The Secretaries urged the industry to prioritise all fuel types that contribute to decarbonisation while reducing India's reliance on oil imports.

While some small-car manufacturers requested specific categorisation, other players opposed the move, arguing that a consensus had already been reached.

The industry maintained that the current format should not be diluted or reconsidered, insisting that no new elements be added to the existing draft.

Government sources indicated that the industry requested more flexibility on super credits for electric and hybrid vehicles. Instead of the proposed three-year and two-year split, manufacturers suggested applying the credits directly at the end of the five-year period, a proposal the government has agreed to consider.

No injustice to the South in delimitation process: PM

NARI SHAKTI. 3 Bills to push women's reservation in Parliament/Assemblies clear LS amid Opposition protests; delimitation exercise to ensure quota doesn't reduce general seats

Dalip Singh
New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday allayed concerns of the Opposition as he gave a "guarantee" that the three Bills aimed at advancing 33 per cent reservation for women in Parliament and the State Assemblies, based on the 2011 Census, would not lead to any "discrimination" or "injustice" to the southern States.

The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, the Delimitation Bill, 2026, and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 were introduced in the Lok Sabha amid strong protests from Opposition members, prompting a division of votes. The legislation secured 251 votes in favour and 185 against its introduction.

The delimitation exercise is to ensure that 33 per cent women's reservation does not reduce the number of seats available to general candidates.

Intervening in the debate, the PM urged members not

to politicise the issue and to support the legislation unanimously. "Today, with all sincerity, I want to say in this Parliament that this decision-making process will not discriminate between South or North and among bigger or smaller States. This decision-making process will not do injustice against anyone. The proportion on the basis of which the delimitation has taken place in the past will not be changed and the increase in the seats will also be corresponding."

AMIT SHAH CLARIFIES

Home Minister Amit Shah stood up twice during the day to clarify the Opposi-

Seats in southern States

State	Current seats (543)	Current % of 543 seats	50% increase (approx.)	New status (% of 816)
Andhra Pradesh	25	4.6	38	4.65
Karnataka	28	5.15	42	5.14
Kerala	20	3.68	30	3.67
Tamil Nadu	39	7.18	59	7.23
Telangana	17	3.13	26	3.18
Total	129	23.76 (Approx. 24%)	195	23.87 (Approx. 24%)

tion's repeated charge of discrimination against the five southern States. He shared comparative data of existing strength and proposed increase in seats in each of the five southern States — Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Kerala — to counter what he insisted was a narrative being peddled by the Opposition.

According to him, as of now a total of 129 MPs represent the southern States in the Lok Sabha, accounting for 23.76 per cent of the total 543 members. This will go up to 195 in a House of 815 if the three Bills are passed, raising seats proportionally in each State by 50 per cent, with a

corresponding minor increase in percentage to 23.87, he added.

INTENT QUESTIONED

Opposition members questioned the timing and intent of the legislation, arguing that promises of a proportionate increase in seats across the States were not backed by explicit provisions in any of the three pieces of legislation.

Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi said what the BJP is doing is a repeat of how it arbitrarily carved up seats in Assam, divided the constituencies of Opposition leaders, and drew up new boundaries for its own benefit.

Wipro Q4 net dips 1.9% y-o-y; weak guidance clouds outlook

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

It was another underwhelming quarter for IT major Wipro. Net income for the March, or fourth, quarter of FY26 stood at ₹3,501 crore, rising 12.3 per cent q-o-q but declining 1.9 per cent y-o-y. For Q1FY27, the company guided for -2 per cent to 0 per cent revenue growth in constant currency (cc) terms, falling short of market expectations.

The Q4 revenue came in at ₹24,236 crore, up 2.9 per cent q-o-q and 7.7 per cent y-o-y. IT services segment revenue, at \$2.65 billion, was up 0.6 per cent q-o-q and 2.1 per cent y-o-y. However, it was largely flat in cc terms, with a 0.2 per cent y-o-y uptick and a 0.2 per cent q-o-q decline.

₹15,000 CR BUYBACK

On Thursday, the board approved a ₹15,000-crore buyback at ₹250 per share, covering up to 60 crore equity

shares, representing 5.7 per cent of the total paid-up equity capital.

The buyback is expected to be completed in Q1FY27, subject to shareholder approval. This marks the largest buyback in the company's history, surpassing the ₹12,000 crore buyback announced in June 2023. At that time, Wipro proposed repurchasing up to 26.96 crore shares, representing 4.91 per cent of its total paid-up equity capital, at a price of ₹445 per share.

Operating margins for Q4 came in at 17.3 per cent, a contraction of 30 bps sequentially, slipping from 17.6 per cent in the previous quarter. For the full year FY26, revenue rose 4 per cent y-o-y to ₹92,624 crore, while the net income grew a marginal 0.5 per cent to ₹13,194 crore.

Employee headcount stood at 2,42,156 in Q4, marginally higher than 2,42,021 in the previous quarter.

Also read p2

Scorecard

	FY26 Q4	Q3	FY25 Q4
Revenue (₹ crore)	24,236	23,560	22,504
Profit (₹ crore)	3,501	3,120	3,569
Margin (%)	17.3	17.6	17.5
Guidance (%)	-2.0 to 0	0 to 2	(-)3.5 to (-)1.5
Attrition (%)	13.8	14.2	15
Employee count	2,42,156	2,42,021	2,33,346

Source: Company report

This
Akshaya Tritiya,
turn Tradition into
Investment
Gold and Silver
ETFs & FOFs



Key Benefits:



Hassle free storage: Funds hold high purity physical Gold and Silver in custody*



Easy liquidity



Invest regularly with small amounts

To know more,
contact your
Broker or
MFD/RIA



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to learn
more

*Respective ETFs invest in physical gold and silver with 99.5% fineness or above for gold and 99.9% fineness or above for silver. Complies with Good Delivery norms as specified by SEBI Regulations. Fund of Fund (FoF) investors also enjoy benefits of hassle-free storage as the FoF invests in the respective ETF units.

An Investor Education and Awareness Initiative

Visit <https://www.hdfcfund.com/information/key-know-how> to know more about the process to complete a one-time Know Your Customer (KYC) requirement to invest in Mutual Funds. Investors should only deal with registered Mutual Funds, details of which can be verified on the SEBI website (www.sebi.gov.in/intermediaries.html). For any queries, complaints & grievance redressal, investors may reach out to the AMCs and / or Investor Relations Officers. Additionally, investors may also lodge complaints directly with the AMCs. If they are not satisfied with the resolutions given by AMCs, they may raise complaint through the SCORES portal on <https://scores.sebi.gov.in/> SCORES portal facilitates investors to lodge complaint online with SEBI and subsequently view its status. In case the investor is not satisfied with the resolution of the complaints raised directly with the AMCs or through the SCORES portal, they may file any complaint on the Smart ODR on <https://smartodr.in/login>.

MUTUAL FUND INVESTMENTS ARE SUBJECT TO MARKET RISKS, READ ALL SCHEME RELATED DOCUMENTS CAREFULLY.

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

SRINI PALLIA
CEO and Managing Director, Wipro



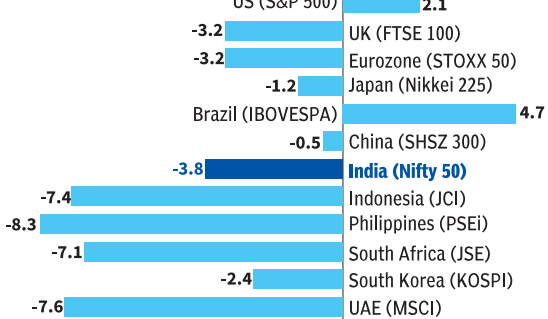
With inputs from intern Adithya Lalgudi

Sourashis Banerjee
Roshan Flavian
Chennai

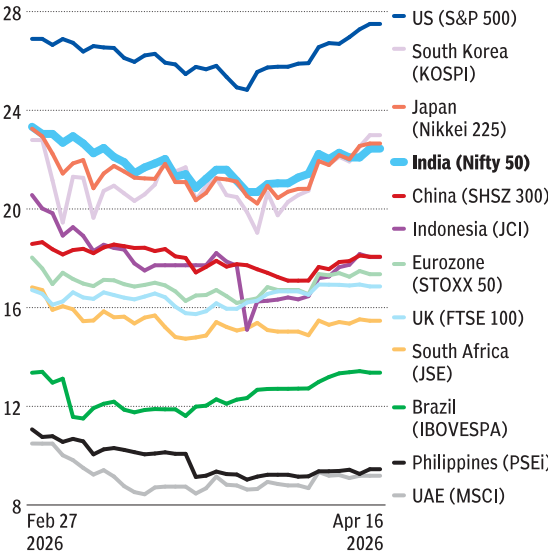
DATA FOCUS.

South Korea, similarly with its massive petroleum

Change in major equity indices between Feb 27, 2026 and April 15, 2026



Movement of price to earnings (P/E) ratios of major benchmark indices



Source: Bloomberg

VALUATION PREMIUM

However, the Nifty 50 currently trades at significantly elevated valuation levels compared to its emerging

Any adverse macroeconomic shift, earnings disappointment, or global risk-off sentiment could trigger sharper corrections in such a richly valued market.

Roshan Flavian is an intern

Our Bureau
Chennai

This is set to include



AIMING HIGH. Francois Provost (left), CEO, Renault Group SAS, and Stephane Deblaise, CEO, Renault Group India

GLOBAL INTEGRATION

The strategy includes plans to integrate India more deeply into Renault Group's global value chain through vehicle, component, and R&D exports, he said, setting

"The Chennai plant was built in 2008 as part of our partnership with Nissan. Less than a year ago, Renault Group took full control of the plant. This decision reflects the confidence we have in our Indian ecosystem," Provost said. The Chennai plant now has a capacity of

“The centre will help us deploy new technologies in India in two key platforms: Renault Group Entry Platform (RGEP) and the Renault Group Modular

Platform (RGMP)," Provost said. Stephane Deblaise, CEO, Renault Group India, said their modular architecture CMF-A is evolving into RGEF. "RGEF is designed to deliver strong value for vehicles below ₹10 lakh and supporting a competitive core line-up well beyond 2030. In the coming months, this evolution will start coming to life through upgraded versions of Kiger and Tribe."

RGMP will also power the next phase of Renault's growth in India, he noted. "By 2030, four products in India will be built on RGMP, including Duster and Bridger," he said. Renault presented the Bridger concept, a multi-energy vehicle, and has a goal to begin its production in India in the second half of next year.

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

“Already we are looking at ₹100 per tonne increase due to packaging cost increase and (polymer) granule cost. While in April we are looking

"If the conflict (in Iran) were to continue... we are going to have issues with in-



Petcoke, a key kiln fuel in cement manufacturing, is becoming more expensive, prompting the company to reduce its usage and shift to domestic coal.

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

“The remaining shareholding (27 per cent) will be acquired after March 31, 2028, and the valuation will be linked to the target company’s business performance,” a company statement said on Thursday.

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



Commenting on the performance of the international business, the company

On the earnings call, Ramon Laguarta, Chairman & CEO, said: "The international business is very strategic to our long-term growth strategy and is one of the key pillars. It has been accelerating."

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

ULTRA-LUXURY & GREEN
Within India, Mumbai holds the second spot in overall luxury car sales, contributing between 20 per cent and 23 per cent of national volumes. Delhi NCR leads on total units — accounting for roughly 29.4 per cent of national sales, driven by corporate demand and a dense concentration of high-net-worth individuals across its satellite cities — but Mumbai consistently rivals or surpasses the capital in the ultra-luxury and performance



COSTLY RIDE. Google searches for premium automotive brands placed Mumbai ahead of Los Angeles, Madrid and Toronto, a study showed ALLEN EGENUSE J

Santosh Iyer, Managing Director of Mercedes-Benz India, told *businessline* that premiumisation in India is being driven as much by digital discovery as by purchasing power, with Mumbai's

Mumbai anchors the western region, which holds a combined national market share of approximately 32.9 per cent. Maharashtra topped electric SUV and MPV sales charts in FY26,

The surge in search interest reflects a widening aspirational base even as actual ownership remains limited. India's luxury car market sells an estimated 45,000–50,000 vehicles annually — growing faster than the broader passenger vehicle segment, but still a fraction of overall demand.

Porsche ranked as the most searched luxury car brand globally with nearly 6,89,000 monthly searches, followed by Lamborghini (4,84,030) and Ferrari (4,28,570). Gordon Murray Automotive (GMA), a British hypercar manufacturer, was placed fourth with 3,54,500 searches, ahead of McLaren and Aston Martin.

Press Trust of India
Kolkata

In 2023, talks between McLeod and Carbon Resources for a strategic partnership had failed.

Under the agreement, the Aditya Khaitan-led manage-

businessline.

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QUICKLY.
‘Even at \$130/b oil price, India to grow 6.3% in FY27’



New Delhi: S&P Global Ratings said the fiscal strain from the energy price shock is unlikely to impact India’s sovereign credit rating over the long term. S&P Director, Sovereign and International Public Finance Ratings, Yee Farn Phua, said considering a baseline assumption of crude at \$85/barrel, India will grow 7.1 per cent in 2026-27. “Even in the alternate scenario, if I were to say, \$130/barrel average, we are still looking at growth at 6.3 per cent... that is still going to be the highest among major economies,” Phua said at a webinar. **PTI**

South Korean President Lee to visit India for 3 days

New Delhi: South Korean President Lee Jae Myung is all set to embark on a three-day visit to India beginning Sunday to bolster bilateral ties in trade, defence and critical technologies, against the backdrop of rising geopolitical upheavals. Lee is expected to hold wide-ranging talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday, following which both the sides are likely to seal agreements to shore up bilateral cooperation in many areas, people familiar with the matter said. “In light of Lee’s visit, the two nations will open a new chapter in economic cooperation in strategic sectors,” South Korea’s NSA Wi Sung-lac said in Seoul. **PTI**

End of sanctions waiver to hit crude supply, push up costs

30-DAY RELIEF. Will not renew general licence on Russian, Iranian oil: US Treasury Secy

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The end of waiver on sanctions by the US on purchasing Russian crude oil (on water) is not expected to immediately halt shipments to India. However, refiners will have to recalibrate operations avoiding sanctioned entities and vessels, which will have a bearing on volume and costs, refiners and analysts said. The 30-day waiver, which expired April 11, allowed delivery and sale of Russian crude oil loaded on tankers between March 12 and April 11.

LICENCE HALT

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on early Thursday said, “We will not be renewing the general licence on Russian oil, and we will not be renewing the general licence on Iranian oil. That was oil that was on water prior to March 11. So all that has been used.” Refiners, analysts and traders said the situation is “complicated and fluid” with too many variables playing simultaneously. Immediate impact is likely a tightening of supply. However, a severe crude crunch is not being anticipated “at this moment”.

STRATEGY RESET
Besides, Indian refiners will have to yet again re-calibrate



TO RE-WORK PLANS. Indian refiners will have to yet again re-calibrate their sourcing strategy balancing availability, cost, logistics and compliance with various sanctions **REUTERS**

their sourcing strategy balancing availability, cost, logistics and compliance with various sanctions. The adjustment is more likely to be operational rather than structural. This will have a bearing on costs, both for purchasing oil and logistics. “It’s unlikely India will completely halt Russian crude. It is not sanctioned. So, this means legal channels, which means higher costs. We also need to wait for more clarity on what Washington is planning next. There are too many variables playing out right now to point at a clear cut scenario. It’s a developing situation,”

said a senior refining sector executive. With geopolitical uncertainty, no immediate end to conflict in West Asia and the continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz (SoH), there is a supply situation in Middle East Gulf region. This fuels more uncertainty. A clear cut answer will have to wait, said another refining sector executive. A trade source opined that India has a three-day window to top up on Iranian crude oil as the US sanctions waiver ends on April 19. Roughly 90 million barrels of Iranian oil is estimated to be at sea. Another refiner said that this could result in tighter

supply conditions depending on how quickly alternative sources are secured. However, for India, the end of the Iranian sanctions waiver may require minor adjustments in sourcing strategy, considering it has not purchased any oil from Tehran since 2019.

NORMAL OPERATIONS
Meanwhile, the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas said on Thursday, “All refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, while sufficient stocks of petrol and diesel are being maintained. Retail outlets across the country are operating normally.”

India buys LNG from US, Oman, Nigeria in March as Qatar, UAE supplies run dry

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi



SLIPPING UP. LNG imports fell 20 per cent year-on-year in March, as supplies from Qatar and the UAE were disrupted due to escalating tensions in West Asia **REUTERS**

India’s imports of liquefied natural gas (LNG) declined 20 per cent year over year to 1.2 million tonnes (mt) in March 2026, as cargoes from its major suppliers Qatar and the UAE dried up after mounting attacks on oil and gas infrastructure in the region. “The country’s LNG sector is among the most exposed in Asia to the Iran conflict, due to its reliance on Qatar and the UAE for nearly 60 per cent of its supply,” Sam Reynolds, Research Lead with the Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA), said in a commentary on Wednesday. While imports from both countries fell to zero by the end of March, India’s shipments from the US, Oman and Nigeria increased during the month to make up some of the shortfall, he added.

LIMITED IMPACT

India’s total natural gas consumption is about 189 million standard cubic meters per day (mscmd), of which 97.5 mscmd are produced domestically. About 47.4 mscmd has been affected due to *force majeure* conditions. Reynolds pointed out that neither China nor India relies on gas or LNG for a significant share of their power generation. In China, the share of gas in the electricity

mix has remained at 3 per cent over the last decade, while in India it has declined to below 1.5 per cent. India has instead turned to coal to mitigate power supply risks, while accelerating the commissioning of new wind and battery storage projects. While meeting peak electricity demand in the upcoming summer will remain a challenge amid the Iran conflict, the power sector in both countries has remained relatively insulated from LNG price shocks, he added. Like China, India’s LNG imports have fluctuated in recent years due to high prices. The country’s annual purchases fell 6.4 per cent in 2025. India’s LNG imports in 2025 were lower than in 2020, the IEEFA commentary said.

ASIAN MARKETS
Reynolds emphasised that Asia’s LNG imports plummeted in March 2026. Asia purchased 20.4 mt of LNG during the month, ac-

cording to Kpler data, down from a monthly average of 22.1 mt throughout 2025. “Even once the conflict is fully resolved, oil and gas facilities in the Persian Gulf will take several months to resume normal operations, and 17 per cent of Qatar’s LNG export capacity will be offline for up to five years. Spot market LNG prices in Asia have doubled since hostilities began and are widely projected to remain elevated through 2027,” the IEEFA said. Monthly figures mask lower imports toward the end of March. In the week ending March 29, Asia recorded its lowest weekly import volumes since October 2023. Imports from Qatar were below 2 mt in March — reflecting cargoes in transit before the conflict began—but fell to zero in the final week of the month, Reynolds said. On a 30-day rolling average basis, shipments to Asia in mid-April reportedly fell to their lowest level since June 2020, he added.

Poor progress in Deep Ocean Mission

M Ramesh
Chennai



DEEP-SEA EXPLORATION. The National Institute of Ocean Technology has developed MATYSA 6000

The ₹4,077-crore Deep Ocean Mission, launched in 2021 to explore and eventually mine critical minerals from polymetallic nodules on the Indian Ocean bed, has made limited progress. With the current year marking the end of the programme, only about 35 per cent of the allocated budget has been spent by the Ministry of Earth Sciences. A Parliamentary Standing Committee on Science and Technology Environment Forests and Climate Change, which examined the ministry’s demands for grants, noted “with concern” that progress “does not appear to be commensurate with the objectives and timelines originally envisaged.” In a recent report, the committee said that “the pace of progress under certain critical verticals of the Mission needs to be significantly accelerated” to achieve intended outcomes within a reasonable timeframe. Polymetallic nodules — potato-shaped mineral-rich concretions — are found scattered across parts of the ocean floor. The International Seabed Authority has allotted India an area of 75,000 sq km in the Indian Ocean for exploratory work. In December, the ministry told Parliament that this area is estimated to hold 366 million tonnes of nodules, containing 0.14 per cent cobalt, 1.14 per cent nickel,

1.09 per cent copper and 25.2 per cent manganese. The National Institute of Ocean Technology, under the ministry, has designed a deep-sea mining system capable of operating at depths of up to 5.5 km. It has also developed MATYSA 6000, a human submersible for deep-sea exploration. However, a fully-integrated mining system is yet to be realised. The ministry attributed the underutilisation of funds to lower spending in the initial phase, citing the “preparatory nature of activities.” Expenditure stood at 40 per cent and 32 per cent of allocations in 2021-22 and 2022-23, respectively, before rising to 48 per cent and 98 per cent in the subsequent two years. The committee has recommended clearly defined and measurable milestones across the Mission’s six verticals, along with fixed timelines and a structured monitoring mechanism to

‘No conflict in Srinivasan engaging McGovern to advise on Norton’

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran

There was no conflict of interest in Venu Srinivasan having engaged Gerry McGovern, who was then the Chief Creative Officer of Jaguar Land Rover, as consultant for Norton Motorcycles, according to Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran. On Wednesday, former Tata Trusts trustee, Mehli Mistry, in a filing with the Charity Commissioner, Mumbai, had alleged conflict of interest and breach of fiduciary duties by Srinivasan, as a Tata Trusts trustee and Tata Sons board member, in having engaged McGovern. In a statement to *businessline*, Chandrasekaran said, “Mr Venu Srinivasan had approached both Mr Ratan Tata and me about engaging Gerry McGovern, for some

brand advisory support with respect to Norton. After discussing, we did not find conflict with JLR and I gave the consent.” Mistry also raised the question whether Srinivasan paid Jaguar Land Rover for using the services of McGovern and sought the Charity Commissioner to direct Srinivasan to disclose such details. There was no response to this particular matter from

Chandrasekaran’s office as of press time. Norton Motorcycles is a wholly-owned subsidiary of TVS Motor.

TRUST APPOINTMENT

Srinivasan, who joined Sir Dorabji Tata Trust in 2016 as one of its trustees, was appointed vice chairman of Tata Trusts in 2018. He is on the board of Tata Sons as non-executive director. He was also chairman and managing director of TVS Motor till 2022, when he became Chairman Emeritus. Mistry, whose reappointment as Tata Trusts trustee was blocked last year, has alleged serious violations in the governance of the Trust. He has raised questions of the legality of the board of trustees, saying that appointments made in the past were in violation of the provisions of the Maharashtra Public Trusts Act, 1950.

HC reserves order on SpiceJet’s plea to review ₹144-crore payment order

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court, on Thursday, reserved order on petitions by SpiceJet and its promoter Ajay Singh, seeking a review of an earlier order to deposit ₹144 crore in connection with its legal dispute with media baron Kalanithi Maran and Kal Airways. Justice Subramonium Prasad reserved the order after hearing the senior counsel appearing for

the parties. On January 19, the court directed SpiceJet and Ajay Singh to deposit ₹144 crore with the registry within six weeks against an admitted liability of ₹194 crore. On March 18, time to make the deposit was extended by four weeks. Ajay Singh and his budget airline sought reconsideration of the March 18 direction on several counts, including financial distress amid the ongoing war in West Asia. SpiceJet, instead,

offered a commercial property in Gurugram as security and informed the court that the Centre was willing to offer it some assistance. Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Ajay Singh and SpiceJet, on Thursday said shutting down the airline would not be in public interest and that the law does not mandate that security can only be in the form of cash and can be in the form of a property, bond or undertaking as well.

West Asia conflict hits inbound tourism by 15-20%, says report

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India’s tourism and hospitality sector is facing renewed external pressures following escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia, the PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry said. According to a report by the industry body, disruptions have been recorded across aviation, inbound tourism, hospitality and restaurant segments, even as domestic demand continues to provide stability. The report noted that the sector, which contributes nearly 8 per cent to GDP and supports over 40 million jobs, had witnessed a V-shaped recovery in 2025, with branded hotel inventory nearing two lakh rooms and domestic aviation traffic crossing five lakh passengers per day. **WAR IMPACT** The report cited that the aviation sector has emerged as the most impacted by the West Asia conflict, with airlines facing flight cancellations, airspace restrictions and rerouting of international services. These disruptions have increased flying time by two-four hours on key routes, raising fuel consumption and operating costs. Currently, fuel accounts for 35-40 per cent of airline operating costs, “further straining profitability”. Dis-

ruptions in West Asia air corridors have reduced connectivity efficiency and increased airfares. As per the report, inbound tourist traffic has declined by 15-20 per cent, particularly in leisure travel, as global travellers adopt a cautious approach amid geopolitical uncertainty. Outbound travel trends, too, have shifted, with Indian travellers increasingly opting for short-haul destinations such as Thailand, Singapore and Vietnam, while long-haul and transit-dependent routes have moderated. On the other hand, the hospitality sector remains supported by domestic travel demand. The report highlighted margin pressures due to rising energy costs, increased input prices and fluctuating foreign demand, particularly in premium and business hotel segments. The restaurant and food services sector is witnessing mixed trends. Insights aligned with the National Restaurant Association of India indicate input cost inflation of 10-15 per cent, driven by higher prices of imported ingredients, logistics and energy. The report pointed out that premium dining and hotel-based restaurants in key tourism hubs have seen a dip in international footfall, while domestic demand and food delivery — contributing 20-30 per cent of revenues for organised players — continue to provide support.

Banking system’s ₹5 lakh crore plus surplus liquidity prompts RBI to hold VRRR auction

Our Bureau
Mumbai



With surplus liquidity in the banking system topping the ₹5-lakh crore mark, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has decided to conduct a Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR) auction on April 17, to suck out a portion of the surplus. The central bank will be conducting a VRRR auction of seven-day tenor for ₹2 lakh crore. As on April 15, surplus liquidity in the banking system amounted to ₹5,21,472 crore.

WACR LEVELS
The effect of the surplus liquidity is underscored by the fact that overnight weighted average call rate (WACR) are being dealt at

5.08-5.09 per cent levels, below the policy repo rate of 5.25 per cent. The RBI endeavours to anchor the operating target — the WACR — to the policy repo rate to ensure that its monetary policy framework is effective. “In view of the surplus transi-

ent liquidity conditions prevail-

ing, it has been decided to conduct a Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR) auction on Friday, April 17, 2026,” per an RBI statement.

PROACTIVE MEASURES
At last Friday’s seven-day VRRR auction, the RBI received offers to deploy funds aggregating ₹2,09,460 crore against the notified amount of ₹2 lakh crore. It accepted the offers aggregating ₹2,00,041 crore at a weighted average rate of 5.23 per cent. In his recent monetary policy statement, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said: “Going ahead, we will continue to be proactive and pre-emptive in liquidity management and ensure sufficient liquidity in the banking system to meet the productive requirements of the economy.”

MEA briefs parliamentary panel on situation in Iran

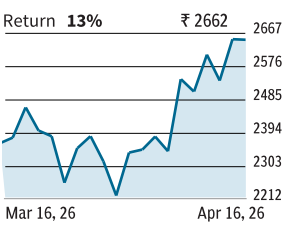
Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Thursday briefed the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs on the fast-evolving situation in Iran, with the discussions covering a wide spectrum of issues, including concerns over potential disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, panel chairperson Shashi Tharoor said. “It was a very good briefing with the foreign secretary on all the issues to deal with the Iran war that were not covered in the earlier briefing when he was himself not present. This time he gave us a comprehensive view. There were a lot of questions asked,” Tharoor said. Tharoor said 17 members attended the discussions.

 Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Ltd Be a step ahead in life	TAMILNAD MERCANTILE BANK LIMITED CIN: L65110TN1921PLC001908 Regd. office: 57, V. E. Road, Thoothukudi – 628 002 Phone: 0461-2321932 (E), 2321929 (E) Website: www.tmb.bank.in e-mail: shareholders@tmbank.in
IMPORTANT NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS Special Window for Transfer and De-matrisation of Physical Shares Pursuant to SEBI Circular No.HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, shareholders are hereby informed that a Special Window has been re-opened for a period of one (1) year, from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027, for the re-lodgement of transfer requests for physical share certificates. This facility is applicable to transfer deeds lodged prior to April 1, 2019 and which were rejected, returned, or not attended due to deficiencies in documents, process, or otherwise and also for transfer deeds executed before April 01, 2019 but not lodged with the Bank. Shareholders are encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity by submitting the requisite documents to the Bank's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent at the address mentioned below: MUFG Intime India Private Limited (formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) Unit: Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Limited, Surya 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore – 641 028. Phone: 0422 - 2314792, 2539835, 2539836 & 4958995 email: investor.helpdesk@in.mpmf.mufg.com	
For Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Limited Sd/- Swapnil Velgaonkar Company Secretary (Membership No: ACS 21877)	
Place: Thoothukudi Date: 16th April, 2026	

QUICKLY.

HDFC AMC Q4 profit
dips 2.4% to ₹623 crore



New Delhi: HDFC Asset Management Company on Thursday reported a 2.4 per cent decline in consolidated profit after tax at ₹622.66 crore for the quarter. It posted a PAT of ₹638.46 crore in the year-ago period, the fund house said in a regulatory filing. However, revenue from operations grew 17 per cent year-on-year to ₹1,051.51 crore in the quarter under review. The company's board has recommended a final dividend of ₹54 per equity share for the financial year ended March 31, 2026. This is subject to shareholders' approval. Also, the board approved the appointment of Rajan Anandan as an invitee and external expert on the Technology Committee. **en**

PropShare Celestia's
IPO subscribed 1.33 times

New Delhi: PropShare Celestia's initial public offering (IPO) received 1.33 times subscription on the closing day of the issue on Thursday. It is the third Small and Medium Real Estate Investment Trust (SM REIT) launched by Property Share Investment Trust. The IPO received bids for 3,090 units against 2,323 units on offer, as per BSE data. Other investors category received 4.81 times subscription, while institutional investors portion got subscribed 17 per cent. The issue has a price band of ₹10-10.50 lakh per unit. The public issue has only a fresh issue of units, with no offer for sale component. The issue generated a demand of ₹324 crore. **en**

Akshaya Tritiya: Gold ETFs shine, jewellery stocks see mixed trend

KEY RISKS. Elevated prices, heightened sensitivity in retail demand could weigh on jewellers, say analysts

Gayathri G
Chennai

As India heads towards the auspicious Akshaya Tritiya (April 19), traditionally associated with gold buying, a sharp rally in the yellow metal over the past year is re-shaping both consumer behaviour and investor strategy. Gold prices have surged to around ₹1.5 lakh per 10 g, up sharply from sub-₹1 lakh levels a year ago, denting affordability for retail buyers.

This has led to a visible shift in consumption patterns, with customers opting for lighter jewellery, exchanging old gold, or deferring purchases altogether. “Foot-falls remain steady, but

ticket sizes have shrunk,” said Anil R, Senior Research Analyst, Geojit Investments.

MARKET SPLIT

Despite these headwinds, the underlying business momentum for organised jewellers has remained resilient, supported by a strong wedding season and network expansion. However, this has not translated uniformly into stock performance.

Market leader Titan Company has continued to outperform, aided by its strong brand, premium positioning and steady execution. In contrast, mid-tier players such as Kalyan Jewellers have seen more volatility.

Brokerages remain constructive on select names. JM Financial has retained Ti-

Contrasting show

	NSE close (₹)	One-year return (%)
ETFs		
Gold BEES	125.6	58.5
SBI Gold ETF	129.5	59.0
HDFC Gold ETF	129.6	58.9
Kotak Gold1	126.6	58.9
ICICI Pru Gold	130.1	59.2
Stocks		
Titan	4,461.4	36.4
Kalyan Jewellers	440.3	-16.3
Thangamayil	4,278.4	108.8
PN Gadgil	662.2	21.3
PC Jeweller	9.5	-30.3

tan Company as its top pick, while CLSA has raised its target price.

Over the past year, Titan has delivered returns of

about 35.6 per cent, while Thangamayil Jewellery has delivered over 104 per cent.

“Valuations in parts of the space look stretched after the recent rally,” said Shruti Jain, Chief Strategy Officer, Arihant Capital Markets, while retaining Titan as a preferred buy on dips.

At the same time, investor behaviour is undergoing a structural shift.

Financial forms of gold, such as ETFs and sovereign gold bonds, are gaining traction over physical jewellery due to lower costs and higher liquidity, analysts said.

“Buying behaviour is becoming purpose-driven, with a tilt toward 18-carat jewellery, coins for investment, and rising preference for ETFs and SGBs,” said Akshat

Garg, Head-Research & Product at Choice Wealth.

WORD OF CAUTION

Looking ahead, experts caution that the sector faces risks of valuation compression if gold prices stabilise or correct. Elevated prices, coupled with heightened sensitivity in retail demand, could weigh on earnings expectations for some players.

Meanwhile, Paresh Bhagat, CIO of Veer Growth Fund (AIF) and Chairman at Mangal Keshav Financial Services, argued that with gold near peak valuations, investors should avoid large lump-sum purchases this Akshaya Tritiya and instead consider disciplined allocation to equities through systematic investment plans.

SEBI strengthens fraud fight with new data sharing pacts

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has stepped up its fight against financial fraud by forging closer ties with key government agencies, signing two separate memoranda of understanding (MoUs) with the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) and the Financial Intelligence Unit-India (FIU-India).

The agreements are aimed at strengthening real-time information sharing and co-ordinated action to curb fraud in the securities market. Together, they signal a more integrated regulatory approach

as financial crimes become increasingly sophisticated and technology-driven.

Under the pact with DoT, SEBI will leverage the department's Digital Intelligence Platform, a secure system designed to enable real-time intelligence sharing among stakeholders..

In parallel, SEBI's agreement with FIU-India focuses on deepening cooperation in tackling money laundering and illicit financial flows linked to the capital markets.

The MoU incorporates global standards such as the Egmont principles for information exchange and is aligned with the requirements of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002.

Sensex, Nifty pare gains to end a tad lower on profit taking

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

The benchmark indices ended marginally lower on Thursday after a volatile session as profit-booking at higher levels and lingering uncertainty around US-Iran talks weighed on sentiment.

Vinod Nair, Head of Research at Geojit Investments, said, “The market ended with marginal losses on weekly expiry amid volatility and profit-booking. He noted that investors remain cautious ahead of further clarity on US-Iran negotiations, while a higher-than-expected WPI inflation print



weighed on auto and consumption stocks.”

The BSE Sensex declined 122.56 points or 0.16 per cent to close at 77,988.68 after hitting an intra-day high of 78,730.32, while the NSE Nifty 50 slipped 34.55 points or 0.14 per cent to

settle at 24,196.75. The volatility index remained stable around 18. However, Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 100 indices gained 0.63 per cent and 0.89 per cent.

Sectorally, metals emerged as the top performers, supported by firm global commodity prices and a softer dollar. IT stocks showed resilience, aided by improving visibility on AI-led demand. Among Nifty 50 constituents, Adani Enterprises, Hindalco, Trent, Eternal and Adani Ports emerged as top gainers, while HDFC Bank, ONGC, Titan, M&M and Bharti Airtel were major laggards.

Mark Mobius, the evangelist of emerging markets investing, no more

Blomberg

Mark Mobius, who put emerging markets on investors' radar with on-the-ground insights over more than four peripatetic decades, has died. He was 89.

He died on Wednesday, according to a post on his LinkedIn page attributed to his spokeswoman, Kylie Wong. John Ninia, a partner at Mobius Investments, said he died in Singapore.

In more than 30 years with Franklin Templeton Investments, officially Franklin Resources Inc, Mobius became an evangelist for money-making opportunities in Africa, Asia, Eastern Europe and Latin America.

Hired in 1987 by John Templeton Mobius started one of the first mutual funds dedicated to developing new markets. He oversaw the Templeton Emerging Mar-



Mark Mobius (1936-2026)

kets Group until 2016, was lead manager of its flagship Templeton Emerging Markets Investment Trust until 2015 and retired in January 2018. From 1989 until his retirement, the closed-end fund returned 13.4 per cent a year on average, according to *Morningstar Direct*.

Since 2001, when the MSCI Emerging Markets Index was introduced, the Templeton fund has beaten that benchmark by 1.9 per cent a year on average. Partly based in Singapore, Mobius travelled 250 to 300 days a

year visiting factories and distributors in remote corners of the globe to identify investment opportunities.

MARKET FORESIGHT

Mobius predicted the start of a bull market in 2009, snapped up bargains during the Asian financial crisis after Thailand floated its currency in 1997 and bought Russian stocks as panic selling took hold in Russia in 1998.

He was also one of the first institutional investors to identify Africa as a promising frontier market, setting up the Templeton Africa Fund in 2012.

Mobius founded London-based Mobius Capital Partners in 2018 and oversaw managed funds investing in emerging market equities.

He was born on August 17, 1936, in Bellmore, New York's Long Island.

SEBI extends not-for-profit registration validity for SSEs

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has relaxed key norms for the Social Stock Exchange (SSE), extending the registration validity for not-for-profit organisations (NPOs) and lowering the minimum subscription requirement for Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) instruments.

In a bid to promote SSEs and facilitate ease of fundraising by NPOs, SEBI has allowed them to remain registered on the SSE for up to three years without raising funds, compared with the earlier two-year limit.

“It is being specified that a NPO may register on a SSE and not raise funds through it for a period of two years from the date of registration. Such a period of two years may be further extended by one additional year subject to approval by the SSE,” the regulator said in a circular on

Wednesday. SEBI has also reduced the minimum subscription requirement for ZCZP instruments to 50 per cent from 75 per cent, subject to conditions.

“The minimum subscription required to be achieved shall be 75 percent... Provided that the minimum subscription... shall be 50 per cent in case where the funds raised can be deployed... in a manner that the implementation of the project remains viable and meaningful,” SEBI said.

The relaxation may apply only to projects where costs and outcomes can be implemented on a clearly identifiable per-unit basis, ensuring that partial funding does not undermine execution.

SEBI also said funds must be refunded to investors if the minimum subscription requirement is not met.

The latest measures build on SEBI's broader push to scale up the SSE framework, which aims to channel capital towards social enterprises.

Bajaj Life Insurance launches low volatility index fund for ULIP holders

Our Bureau
Chennai

Bajaj Life Insurance on Thursday launched the Nifty 500 Low Volatility 50 Index Fund under its ULIP.

The fund's USP lies in its rules-based, passive strategy that selects 50 relatively stable stocks from the broader Nifty 500 universe, ensuring a diversified yet defensively positioned portfolio with a strong large-cap bias (79 per cent), while the remaining will be distributed across mid-cap and small-cap segments, the insurance major said in a statement.

Benchmarking against the Nifty 500 Low Volatility 50 Index, the fund aims to deliver steady compounding by reducing market fluctuations while maintaining exposure to India's equity growth story.

The New Fund Offer will close on April 30.

BROKER'S CALL.

Monarch Network

IVALUE INFOSOLUTIONS (BUY)

Target: ₹330
CMP: ₹257.05

We initiate coverage on iValue Infosolutions with a Buy and a TP of ₹330. Ivalue is India's only listed VAD (value added distributor) specialising in creating solutions across cybersecurity, ILM, ALM, Cloud and Data centres. Strong partnerships with leading OEMs like Hitachi Vantara, Checkpoint, Forcepoint, etc., along with System Integrators (SIs) like Infosys, TCS and Deloitte, among others, demonstrate its robust business model.

Ivalue has maximised on the cloud opportunity by working with System Integrators on large deals like Aadhar and GST. As a VAD, Ivalue provides solutions across BFSI, IT, Telecom & Government. Presence across high-growth segments, a large addressable market, strong conversion ratio (25 per cent+), and a credible history provide strong visibility and comfort. Being a low capex, high return ratio and healthy margin business (especially among distributors), we expect Ivalue to report stronger growth.

The financial strength is reflected in a track record of solid topline growth, 2x the margins of vanilla distributors, along with 20 per cent + return ratios. We see Ivalue delivering 19 per cent + EPS CAGR over FY25-28.

Key risks: Vendor concentration risk, margin compression risk (large deals) and working capital/credit risk.

JM Financial

VA TECH WABAG (BUY)

Target: ₹1,755
CMP: ₹1,440.85

VA Tech Wabag is a leading pure-play water technology multinational headquartered in Chennai, India, with over 10 decades of experience in sustainable water and wastewater management. It provides comprehensive solutions across the entire water cycle, spanning desalination, wastewater treatment, water recycling and reuse, ZLD, and waste-to-energy solutions. Wabag maintains a well-diversified portfolio with a balanced mix of municipal and industrial projects, supporting sustainable infrastructure development globally. With a strong presence in more than 25 countries across the globe, over 125 proprietary technologies and deep-rooted R&D, it combines advanced in-house technologies with engineering expertise to deliver customised, cost-effective solutions tailored to regional needs. Its operations span design-build projects and long-term operation and maintenance contracts, delivering consistent value to clients and communities. At end-Dec'25, Wabag had a robust order backlog of ₹15,100 crore (4.1x TTM revenue). Wabag sees an opportunity of ₹40,000 crore in the Indian and global markets of presence over the next 12-18 months.

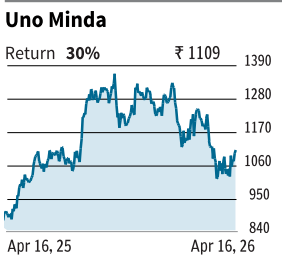
We estimate PAT to grow at 17 per cent CAGR over FY25-28E. The stock currently trades at 20x/18x FY27/28E EPS. We value the stock at 23x FY28E EPS to arrive at a target price of ₹1,755. We initiate coverage at BUY.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY'S PICK.

Uno Minda (₹1,109.70): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Uno Minda has been in a downtrend since the beginning of this year. However, over the past month, it was in a consolidation phase, and this week, it has broken out of a key resistance at ₹1,090.

Also, for more than a week now, the price could sustain above the 21-day moving average.

These are signs of a bullish trend reversal. Nevertheless, there is a possibility of a minor correction in price before the next leg up. So, participants can go long now at ₹1,109 and accumulate at ₹1,080. Place

stop-loss at ₹1,050. When the price rises to ₹1,140, revise the stop-loss to ₹1,080. On a further uptick in stock price to ₹1,160, alter the stop-loss to ₹1,120. Book profits at ₹1,180.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24186 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
24100	24000	24350	24500	Buy if the contract surpasses 24350; place stop-loss at 24180.	

₹795 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
790	775	810	820	Stock trading near range bottom; go long with stop-loss at 785.	

₹1318 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1300	1270	1330	1355	Buy the stock if it breaks out of 1330; keep a stop-loss at 1310.	

₹303 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
300	298	305	310	Go long on the stock on a breakout of 305; place stop-loss at 300.	

₹282 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
280	276	286	290	Buy the stock if it rebounds from 280; keep a stop-loss at 276.	

₹1343 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1330	1315	1355	1375	Buy the scrip if it breaks out of 1355; keep a stop-loss at 1330.	

₹1067 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1060	1040	1085	1120	Buy the stock on a breakout of 1085; place a stop-loss at 1060.	

₹2577 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2535	2500	2600	2680	Go long if there is a breakout of 2600; keep a stop-loss at 2575.	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Amid weak sentiment, few cos may cut IPO size by half

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

For companies caught between weak market sentiments and funding needs, the option to sharply cut IPO size, in some cases by as much as half, could offer a middle path, with industry participants expecting issuers to use the flexibility selectively depending on their comfort with lowering the raise.

DEAL SUPPORT

The markets regulator may allow companies going public to cut their issue sizes by as much as 50 per cent without much paperwork amid the weak investor sentiment and geopolitical uncertainties. Market participants said the relaxation is unlikely to be exercised uniformly but could help unlock deals that are otherwise at risk of being deferred.

“The recent regulatory flexibility is optional in nature and will be exercised only by those promoters who are comfortable recalibrating their fundraise,” said Narinder Wadhwa, Managing Director and CEO of SKI Capital Services.

While a reduced issue may not fully meet original fundraising plans, it can still address immediate funding requirements. Wadhwa said companies may still be able to “tap the market, secure essential funding, and avoid indefinite delays,” even if the raise is smaller than initially envisaged.

“There are several companies keen to list, and what's been holding them back is really the size of their originally planned IPO and exit expectations of selling shareholders,” said Manan Lahoty, Partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. “For these issuers, a smaller raise is clearly preferable to defer-

SEBI may allow companies to cut their issue sizes by as much as 50% with less paperwork due to weak investor sentiment amid geopolitical uncertainties

ring the listing altogether.”

Companies may prioritise essential capital expenditure, debt repayment, and near-term needs while deferring less critical expansion. At the same time, regulatory safeguards are expected to ensure that the core objectives of the issue are not diluted, with any reduction largely coming from secondary components or discretionary allocations.

“The relaxation is case-specific, time-bound, and conditioned on regulatory approval, public disclosure, and certification by lead managers that compliance remains intact. That suggests the bar for readiness remains high,” Rohit Jain, Managing Partner at Singhania & Co, said.

By aligning supply closely with demand, issuers may see improved subscription dynamics. Wadhwa said such calibration could support “better price discovery” and lower the risk of weak listing performance.

“If issuers can right-size their offerings while still meeting investor expectations on liquidity, these IPOs should find takers. Smaller, well-priced issues are often easier to place in a cautious market, and that typically leads to healthier demand discovery,” Lahoty said.

Institutional investors may remain selective, while retail interest could be supported by reasonably sized and priced offerings.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 34.55 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
L&T	4119.80	11.14	29.86	4.36	
Infosys	1319.20	10.63	19.10	4.17	
Eternal Ltd.	252.70	9.48	1055.69	1.64	
Hindalco	1039.90	8.98	14.53	1.36	
Bharat Elec	455.65	6.25	55.86	1.47	
Adani Ports	1549.80	6.12	28.57	1.03	
Trent Ltd.	4083.30	5.09	89.61	0.82	
TCS	2576.90	4.90	18.85	2.37	
Tata Steel	210.69	3.55	28.83	1.57	
Adani Enter	2203.70	3.37	18.80	0.52	
ITC	303.40	2.84	18.36	2.64	
Asian Paints	2440.30	1.70	59.86	0.99	
Maruti Suzuki	13335.00	1.32	28.08	1.58	
TataConsumerProduct	1102.60	1.19	74.15	0.65	
UltraTech Cement	12826.00	1.06	45.48	1.26	
Tech Mahindra	1491.00	1.00	31.82	0.85	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1022.75	0.55	21.04	1.29	
Bajaj Finserv	1829.90	0.52	15.25	0.95	
Dr Reddys Lab	1221.40	0.48	18.46	0.67	
Cipla	1230.50	0.43	21.93	0.62	
SBI Life	1974.70	0.36	79.89	0.80	
Wipro	210.26	0.32	16.54	0.54	
NestleIndia	1257.40	0.13	74.34	0.81	
Max Healthcare	990.65	0.10	67.93	0.66	
Eicher Motors	7131.00	0.09	36.51	0.88	
PowerGrid Corp	312.25	-0.20	18.71	1.28	
HCL Tech	1450.20	-0.25	23.89	1.38	
Tata Motors PV	356.30	-0.73	48.45	0.67	
JSW Steel	1214.90	-0.76	38.26	1.03	
Sun Pharma	1693.10	-0.81	27.09	1.62	
Bajaj Auto	9825.00	-0.97	30.91	0.98	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	241.27	-0.99	95.52	0.71	
Reliance Ind	1343.30	-1.18	18.59	8.18	
Int'lGlobeavi	4608.70	-1.45	55.49	0.94	
Coal India	432.75	-1.51	8.96	0.89	
WIPAC	390.80	-1.86	15.36	1.67	
Apollo Hosp	7553.00	-2.00	58.21	0.70	
Grasim Ind	2717.30	-2.00	19.52	0.93	
HDFC Life	631.50	-2.10	72.08	0.61	
Hind Unilever	2139.10	-3.58	49.99	1.71	
Axis Bank	1349.60	-3.69	15.88	3.49	
State Bank	1067.15	-3.94	11.38	3.99	
ICICI Bank	1345.50	-4.06	17.02	8.67	
ONGC	282.75	-4.11	7.91	0.99	
Bajaj Finance	905.90	-4.23	30.76	2.19	
Kotak Bank	379.15	-5.22	20.06	2.52	
Titan	4461.40	-5.47	83.10	1.66	
M&M	322.20	-6.67	23.71	2.60	
Bharti Airtel	1940.60	-10.31	30.27	0.59	
HDFC Bank	795.45	-48.25	15.81	10.98	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 731.25 pts.
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Adani Power .	1193.19	113.96	32.97	3.25	
Vedanta	782.85	80.58	18.48	5.42	
Hindustanaeronautics	4363.40	66.52	32.80	3.25	
Punjabindra	4659.98	58.16	4.54	2.72	
Varun Beverages.	460.40	57.37	50.85	2.57	
Adani Energy Solutions .	122.62	50.39	61.61	1.73	
Divis Lab	6293.50	41.61	67.40	3.26	
Race	364.20	41.62	5.56	1.85	
Tata Motors Cv	442.00	40.12	98.84	3.76	
Hyscorp India India .	27.20	28.62	26.60	1.73	
Litmidred	4730.00	25.53	28.69	1.79	
CholamandalamInfina	1569.93	23.33	27.59	2.74	
Tata Power	62.46	22.65	27.22	2.91	
Adanirenewenergy	1118.90	21.63	99.30	1.53	
Gail (India)	158.92	21.32	12.14	1.75	
Bagaj Holdings	10205.00	17.90	126.7	1.80	
India Infrateils Co.	15.74	15.74	42.33	1.53	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	77.50	15.30	107.30	2.11	
Hindus Zinc	592.50	14.69	21.21	1.05	
Comminis India	5038.20	13.27	62.30	2.77	
Macrotech Developers .	3745.00	10.33	26.08	1.00	
Bosch	8740.00	8.81	40.06	1.32	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	1103.24	8.63	19.26	0.85	
India Infrateils	1218.30	7.21	62.15	1.53	
Solar Industries	14990.00	7.15	88.85	4.49	
Ambuja Cements	458.65	6.97	23.01	1.14	
Mazdaag Dock	256.60	5.60	42.98	0.79	
Three Cement	25110.00	5.47	50.44	3.37	
Punjab Natl Bank	113.56	4.67	7.30	1.59	
Tata Capital	335.90	4.45	31.23	1.59	
Adani Ports	407.70	4.07	32.82	4.54	
Zydusfiscals	939.10	2.15	18.80	0.96	
United Spirits	1254.50	1.75	53.05	1.51	
Bank Of Baroda	279.39	1.68	7.35	2.11	
Pidilindia	6883.50	1.55	86.50	1.47	
Abidit	1331.00	1.31	58.54	1.68	
Hdfc bank	2662.20	-0.86	36.68	2.21	
Torrent Pharma	4155.90	-1.00	61.91	1.77	
Union Bank	188.49	-1.20	7.60	1.48	
Siemens	3563.80	-3.07	80.05	1.28	
Siemens Energy India .	2901.30	-4.24	87.46	1.05	
Godrej Consumer	1081.15	-4.94	60.73	1.77	
Muthootfin	3578.00	-6.05	16.60	1.56	
India Infrateils	15.74	-5.47	42.33	1.53	
SamvardhanaInternatlnal	122.82	-9.12	5.62	2.21	
Indian Oilcorp	144.19	-10.86	5.52	2.19	
Bpcl	307.95	-14.30	5.43	2.54	
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3757.20	-17.30	58.46	3.59	
Avenueuper	4428.20	-18.70	100.61	2.66	
Britania Ind	5596.00	-22.78	55.68	2.68	

QUICKLY.

Aliste Tech raises ₹30 cr in pre-Series A round



Bengaluru: Aliste Technologies has raised ₹30 crore in a pre-Series A round comprising a mix of equity and debt, led by Big Global JSC, with participation from existing investor YourNest Venture Capital and manufacturing partner Hbeon Labs. The start-up said the capital will be used to deepen its research into energy-aligned solutions and expand distribution, as it sharpens its focus on enterprise energy optimisation across sectors. **OUR BUREAU**

Candescent opens tech centre in Hyderabad

Hyderabad: Candescent, a US-based intelligent digital banking platform, has inaugurated a technology centre here, employing 260 people, expanding its operations in the city. The 30,000 sq ft facility will be a core engineering and innovation hub for the company's global needs. The platform supports over 1,300 banks and credit unions, serving about 30 million users in the US. **OUR BUREAU**

'Retrospective' grid mechanism puts green energy firms under pressure

SERIOUS CONCERNS. Industry approaches Renewable Energy Ministry for softening regulator's order

Richa Mishra
Hyderabad

The recent change in the commercial mechanism used to maintain grid discipline and security mandated by the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC) has domestic green energy producers worried and knocking at the doors of the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy for reconsideration or dilution.

Termed as Deviation Settlement Mechanism (DSM), it is meant to ensure that grid users (generators and buyers) adhere to their scheduled injection or drawal of electricity.

In the energy sector, DSM refers to two distinct but related regulatory frameworks: DSM (supply-side grid discipline) and demand side management (consumer-side efficiency).

The CERC, through its order dated March 31, 2026, has determined the value of "X" for computation of deviation (in per cent) for wind, solar and hybrid (wind/solar) sellers under the Deviation Settlement Mechanism Regulations, 2024, applicable from April 1, 2026, onwards.

This order operationalises a fundamental change in the deviation computation framework by initiating a transition from an available capacity-based method to a scheduled generation-based method, through a phased reduction of the parameter "X".

The decision applies not only to new projects but also to existing renewable energy projects commissioned under earlier regulatory regimes, including those competitively bid and commissioned around 2017-2018.

From April 1, the deviation percentage for wind and solar sellers will be computed using a weighted denominator comprising X per cent of available capacity and (100-X) per cent of scheduled generation.

This is a serious challenge for renewable energy projects commissioned around 2018, including those awarded through competitive bidding under Section 63 of the Electricity Act, on the basis of a regulatory framework.

At the time of bidding and financial closure, there was no indication in regulations, statements of reasons, or bid documents that such a ma-



STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT. The simultaneous tightening of deviation bands materially increases exposure to DSM charges

terial structural change would be introduced.

RIISING CONCERNS

The subsequent modification of the deviation computation framework therefore gives rise to concerns of promissory estoppel and breach of legitimate expectations. While the order applies prospectively from April 2026, it retrospectively alters the economic assumptions underlying investments already made.

The simultaneous tightening of deviation bands materially increases exposure to DSM charges. Empirical studies referenced by CERC indicate that, under tightened bands, projects remain outside the revenue-neutral range for a substantially higher proportion of time. This increases both the frequency and quantum of

payable DSM charges, particularly for wind projects which face higher natural variability and forecasting uncertainty. According to multiple sources, the industry players as well as National Solar Energy Federation of India have urged policy makers not to apply the regulations retrospectively to projects bid under earlier regulatory regimes.

Subrahmanyam Pulipaka, CEO of National Solar Energy Federation of India, told *businessline*, "India's current weather forecasting operates at a spatial resolution of approximately 12 km X 12 km with updates twice daily, whereas power system scheduling operates in 15-minute time blocks."

"Although efforts are underway to improve resolution to 4 km X 4km, the inherent mismatch between

Godrej Capital eyes ₹50,000 crore AUM in two years

Our Bureau
Chennai

Godrej Capital, the financial services arm of the Godrej Industries Group, is looking to grow its assets under management (AUM) to ₹50,000 crore in the next two years. The company is also eyeing entry into new product categories including gold loans.

The company closed the financial year ending March 2026 with an AUM of ₹27,500 crore, up nearly 60 per cent from the ₹17,000 crore in FY25. The company posted profits of ₹375 crore in FY26 compared to ₹175 crore last fiscal.

Speaking at a press conference here on Wednesday, Manish Shah, MD and CEO, Godrej Capital, said the company will look to grow through an expansion of its branch footprint and new product categories.

"Today, we are in about 100 locations and we want to grow this to over 200 locations. We want to enter new businesses like gold loans, supply chain finance and digital lending," he said.

COMPANY PORTFOLIO

Gold loans is an area of particular focus with the company planning to launch the product by June. Shah said the target is for a ₹1,000



Manish Shah, MD and CEO, Godrej Capital

crore AUM in gold loans by the next two years.

Godrej Capital includes two entities: Godrej Housing finance focuses on home loans and Godrej finance, a non-banking finance company that specialises in se-

cured and unsecured business loans. The bulk of the company's AUM comes from Godrej Finance, which has around ₹18,000 crore AUM.

In terms of impact of tariff-led disruption and the war in West Asia, Shah said that the business has shown overall resilience though the company has taken note of possible sectors facing stress and may recalibrate its exposure to some of the impacted sectors such as merchandise exports if the issues persist.

On Godrej Capital's presence in Tamil Nadu, Manish said that the company's AUM in the State stood at ₹1,570 crore, up from the

₹800 crore in FY25. It operates branches across seven cities including Chennai, Madurai, Coimbatore and Tiruchirappalli, among others.

He said that currently the company's presence in Tamil Nadu is dominated by small business financing, but the firm intends to grow housing finance and other segments as well. It is eyeing AUM of ₹2,800 crore in Tamil Nadu by FY27.

Interestingly, out of the firm's ₹1,250 crore of AUM under its 'Aarohi' programme for supporting women-led business, ₹200 crore is from Tamil Nadu — the highest in the country.

Google removed over 483 million ads in India in 2025

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Google blocked or removed 483.7 million policy-violating advertisements and suspended 1.7 million advertiser accounts in India in 2025 with the help of its AI platform Gemini. Globally, it blocked or removed over 8.3 billion bad ads and suspended 24.9 million advertiser accounts last year, according to its '2025 Ads Safety Report' released on Thursday.

The company stated that the integration of its Gemini artificial intelligence models has dramatically improved its ability to detect and stop bad actors in real time.

Of the ads removed globally, Google said it stopped over 99 per cent before they were seen by users.

Fintech IPOs hit pause amid weak rupee, retail pullback

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Public listing plans of new-age fintech companies are being deferred as a weakening rupee, volatile macroeconomic conditions and a sharp drop in retail investor participation dampen sentiment in India's primary markets.

Several start-ups that were preparing to tap the public markets are now recalibrating timelines, with investors advising caution amid currency pressures and valuation concerns. The rupee, among Asia's weakest performers this fiscal, has

added to cost pressures for companies with global exposure, while market volatility has made pricing more challenging.

"The question for quality fintech companies has never really been 'can you IPO?' It's always been 'should you, and when?'," said Arjun Malhotra, General Partner at Good Capital. "For domestically anchored fintechs with strong unit economics, this is more a timing question than an existential one," he added.

Investors said the current phase is pushing start-ups to strengthen fundamentals rather than rush to list. Many venture-backed fintech firms

are focusing on profitability, cost discipline and building predictable revenue streams before approaching the market.

"Patience holds the key. It's the long game. Companies need to demonstrate four to six quarters of consistent profitability and cash-flow positivity before considering a listing," said Brijesh Damodaran, Managing Partner at Auxano Capital.

'MARKET MOOD'

The slowdown in retail investor participation, which had been a key driver of strong IPO demand during the market's peak phase, has further altered the equation.

Market participants said the earlier frenzy often enabled aggressive pricing, a trend that is now reversing.

"Retail participation is a signal of market mood, not business quality," Malhotra said. "During the peak years, it masked weak listings — companies could price aggressively and get away with it. What's left now is the real question: Would institutional investors want to own this at this price?"

As retail demand cools, fintech companies are increasingly being pushed to rely on institutional investors for anchor commitments and long-term capital support. This shift is expected

to bring greater discipline to pricing and valuation strategies.

Damodaran added that softer retail interest is acting as a "reality check" for issuers. "To offset lower retail participation, companies must secure stronger institutional anchors and ensure pricing that supports long-term post-listing stability rather than short-term gains," he said.

With macroeconomic uncertainty persisting, most investors expect IPO activity in the fintech space to remain muted in the near term, with a revival contingent on currency stability and improved market confidence.

Chakraborty's resignation from HDFC Bank not a financial threat: InGovern

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Atanu Chakraborty

The resignation of Atanu Chakraborty as HDFC Bank's Part Time Chairman is a governance stress-test at a big bank, not a breakdown in financial stability, operational integrity or board functioning, according to InGovern Research Services.

The corporate governance advisory services firm observed that the aforementioned episode is more about a governance-over-sight nuance driven by an individual's personality rather than a material threat to shareholder value.

Chakraborty resigned citing "certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over last two years, are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics," without specifics on operations or finances.

InGovern, in a note, said at banks of HDFC Bank's size and complexity (advances ₹30,57,500 crore and deposits ₹31,05,500 crore as at March 31, 2026 — up 10.2 per cent and 14.4 per cent y-o-y respectively; strong CASA franchise, large overseas footprint), strategic or cultural-tone disagreements among board members are not unheard-of, and are often treated as part of the governance stress-test rather than a fatal flaw.

NO REPERCUSSIONS

The firm observed that the bank's steps after Chakraborty's resignation had been practical and governance-focused, with an experienced interim chairman being appointed with RBI approval and retention of a strong, stable top-level management team and undertaking an external legal review of the resignation to uphold standards.

There are no visible signs of disruption in disclosed financial metrics, it added.

Shriram Subramanian,

Managing Director, InGovern Research Services Pvt Ltd, said, "The Chairman's resignation on March 18 led to panic among shareholders as the resignation letter triggered governance conversations relating to the bank."

GOOD RESULTS

"The bank continues to report good financial results, and this seems to be a one-off aberration and a personality driven issue. The chairman's resignation letter and statements, in the press later, failed to highlight any specific instances of alleged governance lapses at the bank," he said.

Shriram said, "The bank should quickly put out the findings by the external lawyers with the review outcomes. The bank should also continue its practices by regular investor engagement and disclosures."

Despite the resignation, HDFC Bank's governance and financial metrics hold up well; investors have no reason for concern on financial strength or leadership, the InGovern note said.

InGovern said, "The bank's deposit franchise remains resilient and lending franchise shows strong momentum. The bank can grow loans and earnings organically while keeping capital-quality intact."

"Profitability gains are less likely to be eroded by sudden credit-cost shocks, which preserves per-share value and dividend-safety," it added.

TTK Prestige
LIMITED

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**NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS
SPECIAL WINDOW FOR TRANSFER
AND DEMATERIALIZATION OF PHYSICAL SECURITIES**

In continuation of our newspaper advertisement published on February 13, 2026 and pursuant to SEBI Circular HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSD-POD/13750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 on Ease of Doing Investment – Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities, a Special Window has been opened by SEBI for a period of one year, from February 05, 2026 till February 04, 2027 for transfer and dematerialisation ("demat") of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2019 which also includes such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and were rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/or otherwise. During this period, the securities that are transferred shall be issued only in demat mode and shall have a lock-in period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Further the cases involving the dispute between the transferor and transferee; and securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) shall not be considered under this window. The Shareholders are hereby encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity and submit the relevant documents mentioned in the said circular with our RTA - KFin Technologies Limited., Unit : TTK Prestige Limited, Selenium Tower B, Plot 31-32, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally Mandal, Hyderabad - 500 032. Email: einward_ris@kfin.tech. For accessing the said circular scan the QR code below:

Place: Bangalore
Date: 16th April, 2026

For TTK Prestige Limited
MANJULA K V
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Sasken Tech sets up CoE, to recruit 100 engineers

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Sasken Technologies Ltd, a product engineering and digital transformation services provider, launched a centre of excellence (CoE) here on Thursday to strengthen its regional delivery footprint and to collaborate with strategic chipset customers like Qualcomm and their original equipment manufacturers. It will hire over 100 specialised engineers to support work at the CoE.

The CoE will focus on engineering across connected devices, 5G-led platforms, Internet of Things solutions, embedded systems and digital product engineering.

As part of the expansion, Sasken appointed Nirmala Datla, Chief Data Science and Engineering Officer, as the Site Leader for the Hyderabad CoE.

"She will drive delivery ex-



Nirmala Datla, Chief Data Science & Engineering Officer, and Site Head (Hyderabad CoE), Sasken Technologies

cellence, build next-generation engineering capabilities and lead talent development from the location," a company executive said.

"Hiring will focus on high-skill roles across semiconductors, automotive and data science and engineering, supporting advanced engineering programmes in connected devices," he added.

PRICOL LIMITED
CIN: L34200TZ2011PLC022194
Regd. Office : 109, Race Course, Coimbatore - 641 018.
Phone : + 91 422 4336000, e-mail: cs@pricol.com
website : www.pricol.com.

NOTICE TO SHARE HOLDERS

1) Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities
Pursuant to SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSD-POD/13750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, shareholders are hereby informed that a Special Window has been opened for a period of one year, from February 5, 2026 to February 4, 2027, for the transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities which were sold / purchased prior to April 01, 2019. This facility is applicable to fresh lodgement and also for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and were rejected, returned, or not attended due to deficiencies in documents, process or otherwise. In compliance with above circular the shares lodged for transfer will be processed only in demat mode and shall be subject to lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Shareholders may avail this opportunity by submitting the requisite documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent.

2) Second 100 Days Campaign-"Saksham Niveshak"- for KYC and other related updations and Shareholder Engagement to prevent transfer of Unpaid / Unclaimed Dividends to IEPF
The Company has initiated second 100 Days Campaign "Saksham Niveshak" starting from 1st April 2026 to 9th July 2026. During this Campaign the Shareholders who have not claimed Dividends or who have not updated their KYC or any issues related to unclaimed dividends and shares may write to the company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent. The shareholders who hold shares in demat form are requested to approach their Depository Participants where they maintain their demat accounts for updating their KYC requirements.
Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent : Integrated Registry Management Services Private Limited, 2nd Floor, "Kences Towers", No.1, Ramakrishna Street, North Usman Road, T.Nagar, Chennai – 600017. Phone: 044 - 28140801 to 28140803.
Email: einward@integratedindia.in

Coimbatore
16th April 2026

For Pricol Limited
T.G.Thamizhanban
Company Secretary

Registered Office: Muthoot Finance Limited,
NH Bypass, Palariavattom, Kochi - 682028, Kerala, India.
Telephone: 0484 2396478, 2394712; Fax : 0484 2396506, 2397399
Email: cs@muthootgroup.com; Website: www.muthootfinance.com
CIN: L65910KL1997PLC011300

NOTICE OF POSTAL BALLOT BY WAY OF REMOTE E-VOTING

NOTICE is hereby given to all shareholders of Muthoot Finance Limited ("Company") that pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 and 110 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules 2014, General Circular No. 03/2025 and any other relevant circulars and notifications issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India, Secretarial Standards -2 on General Meeting (SS-2) issued by Institute of Company Secretaries of India, Regulation 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and other applicable provisions of the Act, Rules, Circulars and Notifications issued thereunder (including any statutory modifications or re-enactment thereof for the time being in force), for seeking the approval of the members of the Company to transact the businesses as contained in the Postal Ballot Notice dated 10th April 2026, by passing the said resolutions through Postal Ballot, only by way of remote e-voting process.

Sl No	Description of Resolution	Type of Resolution
1	To Approve the Alteration of Object clause of the Memorandum of Association of the Company	Special

Pursuant to the Circulars, the Company has completed the dispatch of the Postal Ballot Notice along with the explanatory statement on 15th April 2026, through electronic mode to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company / Depository Participants as on 10th April, 2026 (Cut-off Date).
The Company has engaged the Services of CDSL for the purposes of providing remote e-voting facility to all its Members. The remote e-voting will be available during the following period:

Commencement of e-voting period:	From 09:00 AM (IST) on Thursday 16th April, 2026
Conclusion of e-voting period:	Till 05:00 PM (IST) on Friday 15th May, 2026

The said Postal Ballot Notice is also available on the website of the Company, www.muthootfinance.com, BSE Limited (BSE), www.bseindia.com, National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE), www.nseindia.com and on the website of e-voting service provider Central Depository Services (India) Limited (CDSL), www.evotingindia.com.
The Board has appointed CS Aswin Devaswomparambil Mohankumar, Practising Company Secretary (ACS 69032, COP 2599), Partner, M/s. S S Bhat & Associates, Company Secretaries as a Scrutinizer for conducting the Postal Ballot / e-voting process in a fair and transparent manner. The Scrutinizer will submit his report to the Chairman of the Company and the results will be announced within 48 hours of closure of the e-voting process and will also be placed on the Company's website and on the website of CDSL and communicated to the Stock Exchanges.
All grievances connected with the facility for voting by electronic means may be addressed to Mr. Rakesh Dadi, AVP, (CDSL,) Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futrex, Marfatil Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or call at toll free no 1800 21 09911

Place: Kochi
Date : 15 April, 2026

For Muthoot Finance Limited
Sd/-
Rajesh A
Company Secretary

Voters cleared by tribunals by April 21 or 27 eligible to vote in Assembly polls

FOR THE PEOPLE. Right to be on the electoral roll and to vote in one’s own country not only constitutional but sentimental, says SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

The Supreme Court has declared that electors purged from the voter list during the West Bengal Special Intensive Revision, but cleared by Appellate Tribunals by April 21 or April 27 should be allowed to vote in the Assembly polls.

The order by a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant spelt a huge reprieve for citizens whose right to vote was denied in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) under the ‘logical discrepancy’ category. Over 34 lakh appeals were filed as on April 11.

The court, issuing directions in exercise of its extraordinary constitutional powers under Article 142, ordered the Election Commission to publish a “supplementary revised electoral roll” containing the names of

those who won their appeals by April 21, ahead of the first phase of polling in West Bengal on April 23, or by April 27, prior to the second phase on April 29.

“Wherever the Appellate Tribunals are able to decide the appeals by April 21 or April 27, as the case may be, such appellate orders shall be given effect to by issuing a supplementary revised electoral roll, and all necessary consequences with respect to the right to vote shall follow. However, it goes without saying that the mere pendency of appeals preferred by excluded persons before the Appellate Tribunals shall not entitle them to exercise their right to vote,” the court ordered.

ORDER DATED APRIL 13 However, those whose appeals remain pending before the tribunals would not be allowed to vote. The order is dated April 13, but published



ALL FOR DIDI. TMC supporters take part in a rally in support of West Bengal Chief Minister and party President Mamata Banerjee at Bhabanipur, Kolkata, on Thursday PTI

on April 16. On April 13, the court had orally observed that the right to be on the electoral roll and to vote in one’s own country was not only constitutional but sentimental.

It had referred to thousands of voters excluded for

“logical discrepancies” and lined up for appeal hearings in West Bengal barely a few days ahead of the Assembly polls.

The court said not all of the 34 lakh and more appeals were filed by those excluded from the electoral roll. A substantial

number of appeals were also filed by objectors aggrieved by several inclusions made in the revised electoral rolls. “All such appeals are required to be adjudicated by the Appellate Tribunals,” the court noted.

The Bench noted that

there was no reason why the orders of the Appellate Tribunals, whether of inclusion into or exclusion from the electoral roll, must not be effectuated before the State goes to poll on April 23 or April 29.

The apex court had ordered the constitution of the Appellate Tribunals on March 10, a direction which also made in exercise of its plenary powers under Article 142. The court had directed that the tribunals would be presided over by former Chief Justices and judges of the High Courts of Calcutta and neighbouring States.

The tribunals were intended to provide a mechanism of appeal for individuals whose claims for inclusion in the electoral roll were rejected by the judicial officers in the objections phase of the SIR. The tribunals would also hear appeals against any inclusions in the electoral roll.

Attempts being made to divide India: Mamata

Our Bureau
Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday alleged that efforts to link bills on amending the women’s reservation law with the delimitation mechanism were part of a “conspiracy” by the BJP government at the Centre to remove names from voter lists and introduce the NRC.

‘DIVIDING INDIA’ Addressing an election rally in Cooch Behar district in North Bengal, Banerjee alleged that attempts were being made to divide India by connecting the women’s reservation and delimitation bills. “Attempts are being made to divide India by linking women’s reservation and delimitation bills. Connecting these bills is a conspiracy

to delete voters’ names and implement NRC,” she said.

“The women’s reservation bill was passed long ago, and why was there a delay in its implementation?” she wondered, adding 37 per cent of Trinamool Congress’ elected MPs in the Lok Sabha are women.

The Trinamool Congress supremo also attacked Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman over the alleged violation of the Model Code of Conduct, accusing the Minister of distributing weaver cards illegally to women.

Sitharaman distributed weaver cards to handloom weavers — identity documents issued by the Union Textiles Ministry that entitle weavers to government subsidies and concessional loans, during her visit to Bengal’s East Bardhaman district on Wednesday.

Time too short to look into ‘mass transfer’ of West Bengal officials prior to polls: SC

The Hindu Bureau
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a petition challenging the decision of the Election Commission to transfer “wholesale” 63 IPS officers and 16 senior bureaucrats, including the Director General of Police and the Chief Secretary, in the “garb of poll-preparedness.”

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the petition raised “substantial questions of law”, but declined to intervene on the ground that elections were scheduled just days ahead.

‘ILLEGAL TRANSFERS’ “The transfer is an attempt to take over the executive



machinery of the State by the Election Commission at the behest of the ruling dispensation of the Central government. The wholesale dismantling of administrative machinery on the eve of the Assembly elections is not a bona-fide exercise of power... Such actions create an administrative vacuum and violate the principle of federalism,” senior advocate Kalyan Bandhopadhyay and advoc-

A Bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant said the petition raised “substantial questions of law”, but declined to intervene

ate Vivek Singh, for petitioner Anarka Kumar Nag, submitted. They said the transfers, including that of the Principal Secretary (Home and Hill Affairs) were made even without consulting the State of West Bengal.

The petition said the Election Commission (EC) has made such “illegality and arbitrary” transfers in other poll-bound States in contravention of Article 324 of the

Constitution and provisions of the Representation of the People Act.

It said the EC had banned the transferred officers from being posted to any election sensitive posts during the duration of the Assembly polls. No reason was given for such an instruction.

Chief Justice Kant said all India officers should not focus only on plum posts.

The petition argued that the “whimsical” mass transfers, smacking of *mala fide*, were meant to “paralysis the bureaucracy of West Bengal.

Officers without any taint on them were transferred with an unreasonable instruction not to assign them any election duties, Bandhopadhyay submitted, urging the court to list the case after elections to decide the question of law.

QUICKLY.

23% contesting in phase-I West Bengal polls face criminal cases: Report

Kolkata: Nearly 23 per cent of the candidates contesting in the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly elections have declared criminal cases against themselves, according to a report released on Thursday by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) and West Bengal Election Watch.

Among the major parties, the BJP has the highest share of candidates with criminal cases, with 106 out of 152 nominees (70 per cent) declaring such cases in their affidavits. Out of the 148 candidates the ruling Trinamool Congress has fielded, 63 have criminal cases (43 per cent), while 43 of the 98 candidates of the CPI(M) and 39 of the 151 nominees of the Congress have also declared criminal antecedents. “Data again show that parties continue to give preference to winnability over clean public life despite repeated court directions,” a representative associated with the report said.

The analysis, based on self-sworn affidavits of 1,475 of the 1,478 candidates contesting in 152 constituencies, said 345 aspirants have declared pending criminal cases, and 294 have disclosed serious criminal charges. The report said 19 candidates have declared cases related to murder, while 105 have reported cases of attempt to murder. As many as 98 candidates have disclosed cases related to crimes against women, including six who have declared rape-related charges. PTI

Mamata Banerjee welcomes infiltrators in Bengal: Assam CM

Kalchini: Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday asserted that while BJP governments in his State and Tripura don’t allow infiltration from Bangladesh, TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee “welcomes” them in Bengal.

Addressing an election rally here in Alipurduar district bordering Assam, Sarma also claimed that the TMC government does not allow fencing on the India-Bangladesh border in West Bengal.

“In Assam and Tripura, BJP governments do not allow infiltration from Bangladesh, but [CM] Mamata Banerjee welcomes them in Bengal,” he alleged.

Sarma said a demographic change was underway in West Bengal owing to illegal immigration, and claimed that the population of Hindus is declining in the State, while that of Bangladeshi Muslims is increasing. Elections to the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held in two phases — on April 23 and April 29. Votes will be counted on May 4. The Assam CM also asserted that the BJP will “surely win” in the North-Eastern State, and “score a century” in the 126-member Assembly when the poll results are out on May 4. PTI



POLL KALEIDOSCOPE



ALL FOR VOTES. (Left) Women riders gather for a two-wheeler rally in support of BJP candidate Vanathi Srinivasan, who is contesting from the Coimbatore North constituency; (middle) an elderly man casts his vote at home in the Royapuram constituency in Chennai on Thursday; and (right) artistes performing during an election rally in support of West Bengal Chief Minister and TMC chief Mamata Banerjee at Bhabanipur, Kolkata, on Thursday BUJOY GHOSH/B.JOTHI RAMALINGAM/PTI



‘Black law’: DMK steps up agitation against delimitation Bill

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Thursday further escalated its protests against the proposed delimitation exercise as part of the Women’s Reservation Bill.

Chief Minister MK Stalin burnt a copy of the delimitation Bill in Namakkal as part of a State-wide protest. Calling the Bill a ‘black law’ and a conspiracy to make Tamils refugees in their own land, the DMK President urged people to hoist black flags in every home and public place.

BLACK FLAGS Many DMK leaders and functionaries across the State heeded his call, carrying out



FIERY PROTEST. (Left) DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin, in Madurai, and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin (right), in Namakkal, burning copies of the delimitation Bill on Thursday

their campaigning activity for the upcoming Assembly polls clad in black and hoisting black flags across the State.

DMK MPs, including TR Baalu, Dayanidhi Maran and

Thamizhachi Thangapan-dian, attended the Parliament session in black.

Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin also burnt a copy of the Bill in Madurai and said that the people of Tamil

Nadu will take to the streets if the number of seats is reduced. “We will raise it before the people of Tamil Nadu, who will come to the streets. We will oppose whatever BJP is trying to do

through delimitation,” he said. DMK’s protest stems from the claim that the seat redistribution based on population could reduce the parliamentary representation of Tamil Nadu and other southern States that adhered to the nation’s call for population control in the 1970s.

OTHER PARTIES Other parties like the Congress, Naam Tamilar Katchi, and the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam also expressed their opposition to the delimitation Bill.

Meanwhile, the Centre on Wednesday sought to allay concerns and clarified that the delimitation, based on the 2011 Census, will lead to a 50 per cent increase in the number of current seats for all States.

Stalin spreading misinformation about delimitation, charges EPS

Press Trust of India
Coimbatore

Dismissing the DMK’s claims about the Lok Sabha constituency delimitation affecting Tamil Nadu, AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Thursday claimed that Chief Minister MK Stalin was spreading misinformation about the Bill.

“Stalin fears defeat in the April 9 Assembly polls and is spreading misinformation about the constituency delimitation proposal,” he said during a poll rally in Coimbatore.

Stating that the Centre had already assured that Tamil Nadu won’t be af-



AIADMK General Secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami in Coimbatore PERIASAMY M

fect, he claimed that delimitation would be done fairly for all States. “He (Stalin) opposes 33 per cent reservation for women to prevent the Central government from gaining credit,” Palaniswami said.

Criticising Stalin for failing to fulfil his election promises,

claimed that during the DMK rule, prices of essential goods, electricity and taxes had sharply increased, and law and order had deteriorated. “In addition to rising crime and drug issues, infrastructure and development projects have stalled, and government employees and the public have been misled,” he said.

AMMA CLINICS Stating that Stalin talks about “Delhi vs Tamil Nadu” while this is a State election, he asked, “Why do they bring Delhi here?” He added that if the AIADMK comes to power, Amma Mini Clinics and canteens would be reopened, and they will be under the CM’s supervision.

QUICKLY.

**Gold shines on
revived rate cut bets**



Gold prices moved higher on Thursday as hopes for a peace deal between the US and Iran helped ease inflation concerns and improved prospects for lower interest rates. Spot gold rose 0.6 per cent to \$4,816.14 per ounce as of 1300 GMT. US gold futures gained 0.3 per cent to \$4,838.10. REUTERS

**Crude oil flat as hopes
over peace talks fade**

Tokyo/Singapore: Crude oil prices were little changed on scepticism that peace talks between the US and Iran will reach a deal to end the war. Brent crude futures were up 9 cents to \$95.02 a barrel at 0427 GMT. US WTI crude futures climbed 44 cents to \$91.73 a barrel. REUTERS

**Aluminium hits 4-year
high on supply worries**



London: Aluminium prices hit a four-year high on Thursday as traders continued to assess the scale of damage to global supply from the US-Israeli war with Iran. Benchmark three-month aluminium on the London Metal Exchange rose 0.4 per cent to \$3,636 a tonne. Copper was down 0.1 per cent at \$13,235, zinc rose 0.8 per cent to \$3,424, lead fell 0.8 per cent to \$1,950. REUTERS

China resumes buying broken rice from India

PRICE EDGE. India’s offering most competitive; Beijing’s imports come at a time when it has alleged the presence of GMO in New Delhi’s shipments

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

China has resumed buying broken rice from India despite rejecting several shipments, citing the alleged presence of genetically modified organisms. However, shipment costs have surged after prices of bunker fuel, used to power ships, surged by 50 per cent due to the Iran war. “Our rice exports continue to countries in West Africa, besides China. We are offering broken rice at \$300-310 f.o.b, but container freight costs have gone up due to a rise in bunker fuel,” said BV Krishna Rao, President,

The Rice Exporters Association of India (TREA). “China is buying broken rice. Charge for a 20-foot container is \$75-80 a tonne, though there is no war surcharge,” said M Madan Prakash, Director at the Chennai-based Rajathi Group of Companies that exports agri produce. The Iran war has not affected export of non-basmati rice from India, though basmati rice shipments are facing problems, particularly to West Asia, said Rao. China began importing Indian broken rice after 2022. During 2021-22, it imported record volumes of broken rice from New Delhi. However, the Indian government



banned the export of broken rice in 2022, fearing a supply shortage due to the crop being hit by weather-related problems. The move comes as a surprise since Beijing raised the issue of the alleged presence of GMOs in Indian rice consignments two months ago, despite Chinese agencies clearing the shipments from India.

Global rice price trend (in \$/tonne)			
	5% broken white April 01	25% broken white April 01	Parboiled April 01
India	337	324	345
Pakistan	347	331	-
Vietnam	368	346	-
Thailand	423	415	439

China rejected quite a few shipments.

EL NINO FACTOR Indian rice prices are currently competitive as the shortage of supplies has pushed up prices of Thailand, Vietnam and Pakistan rice, he said. At \$335-339 a tonne, Indian 5 per cent broken white rice is the most competitive

in the global market. Thailand is quoting \$423, Vietnam \$344-348 and Pakistan \$345-349. New Delhi-based trade analyst S Chandrasekaran said the paddy harvest in Thailand and Vietnam is due later this month. “Rice prices may begin cooling this month-end or early April. However, the threat of the emergence of Super El Nino

may prevent any sharp fall in rice prices,” he said. Usually, El Nino leads to drought and longer dry periods in Asia, particularly countries such as India, Thailand, Indonesia, the Philippines and Vietnam. “Malaysian government agencies are beginning to cover for any such eventuality,” he said, adding that countries in the South-East Asia region are also covering for any conflict that may arise between China and Taiwan. TREA’s Rao said demand for rice continues to be normal in the global market. In India, the rabi paddy crop is healthy and good. “Rabi paddy harvest is expected to

be good,” he said. One reason rabi paddy is good is that South India has not been affected by unseasonal rain and hailstorms that lashed parts of North India in March, leading to loss in the wheat crop. Initially estimated at 120 million tonnes, wheat production is now expected to be 5-10 per cent lower. India’s rice production is estimated to be above a record 150 million tonnes during the 2025-26 crop year, ending June. “Besides bunker fuel price and currency fluctuations are also leading to uncertainty. Such situations lead to price rise,” said Chandrasekaran.

Sugar output rises 8% to 27.39 mt in current season till April 15

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Sugar production has reached 27.39 million tonnes (mt) so far in the 2025-26 season from 25.43 mt in the year-ago period, up by 8 per cent mainly on higher output in Maharashtra and Karnataka, according to co-operative industry body NFCSP. Sugar output was 26.2 mt in the entire 2024-25 season (October-September). As the current season ends on September 30, there is scope to add more sugar from the second season in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka during August-September. Of the 21 mills currently in operation, 11 are in Tamil Nadu, 9 in Uttar Pradesh, and 1 in Haryana. Mills in UP and Haryana are likely to end

crushing this month.

STATE-WISE DATA Per the National Federation of Cooperative Sugar Factories Ltd (NFCSP), sugar output in Maharashtra, the top producer, rose 23 per cent to 9.92 mt as of April 15. In Karnataka, the third-largest producer, production has increased by 17 per cent to 4.71 mt (4.04 mt). But in Uttar Pradesh, the second-largest sugar producer, this year it has declined by 2 per cent to 8.92 mt from 9.1 mt. The all-India average sugar recovery was higher at 9.55 per cent till April 15 of this season against 9.37 per cent a year ago. Of the 541 mills in operation, crushing has been closed in 520, whereas in the year-ago period, 499 mills had closed by April 15.

Basmati exporters urge govt to scrap ₹83/tonne levy

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Basmati exporters have urged Apeda to immediately suspend or withdraw the levy of ₹70 per tonne plus GST being charged on contract registration and collected for the Basmati Export Development Foundation (BEDF) as the industry is passing through an exceptionally difficult period due to the US-Iran war. Pointing out that exporters were already under severe financial and operational stress due to war-related disruptions, delayed realisations, higher freight, higher insurance, blocked funds and shrinking margins, it said annual collection itself would be extraordinarily high.

WAR DISRUPTIONS “It is also pertinent to note that annual export of basmati rice is more than 60 lakh



HEADWINDS. Shippers are already under severe financial and operational stress due to war-related disruptions, delayed realisations, higher freight and blocked funds

tonnes (lt) and at ₹70 per tonne rate, the yearly collection by Apeda/BEDF works out to more than ₹42 crore, excluding GST. This itself reflects the magnitude of the burden being imposed on the trade,” said the Haryana Rice Exporters’ Association (HREA).

In a letter to Abhishek Dev, Chairman, Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (Apeda), on April 7, HREA President Sushil Jain said that the current international situation and war-related disturbances in key trade routes and

markets had substantially worsened export conditions. Exporters were facing delay/blockage of export payments, shipment delays, cargo rollover, cargo diversion or return, demurrage, detention, warehousing expenses, higher freight, war-risk surcharge, emergency shipping charges and increased marine insurance premiums. The levy becomes extremely substantial when viewed in terms of actual export volumes, Jain said for instance, an exporter has to pay a total ₹41.3 lakh (including GST) to export 50,000 tonnes of basmati, and it rises to ₹1.65 crore for 2 lakh tonnes. “This clearly shows that the levy is not minor or nominal, but a very heavy financial burden on exporters, especially when margins are already under severe stress,” he added. The Indian Rice Exporters’ Federation (IREF) has

also written to Apeda seeking immediate suspension of the levy. **PRICE-SENSITIVE** Rajeev Setia, IREF’s Acting President of the basmati rice division, said, in August 2025, the processing fee was raised to ₹70 per tonne from ₹30 for issuance of RCAC (Registration-Cum-Allocation Certificate) for basmati rice exports. With GST, the burden on exporters further escalated to ₹82.60 a tonne, he said. Pointing out that Indian basmati exporters operate in highly price-sensitive markets such as the Middle East and the EU, he said the added costs cumulatively erode India’s price advantage over Pakistan, especially for large-volume shipments. Small and medium exporters, who form a significant share of the ecosystem, are likely to be hit harder, potentially reducing their participation in export markets.

Pulses import value down 35% in FY26 on lower volumes, prices

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The pulses import bill during financial year 2025-26 declined around 35 per cent to \$3.57 billion from the previous year’s record \$5.44 billion on reduced volumes and value of the legumes. In value terms, pulses imports were down 31.52 per cent at ₹31,793 crore during 2025-26, against ₹46,427 crore in the year-ago period, per the government data. The total volume of pulses is expected to be around 5.6-5.7 million tonnes (mt) during 2025-26, down from the previous year’s record purchases of 7.3 mt, according to the trade. “Drop in volumes and lower value of the pulses contributed to the decline in the value of pulses imports during FY26,” said Satish Upadhyay, Secretary, India Pulses and Grains Association (IPGA), the apex trade body. Prices of all major varieties of pulses such as gram (chana), yellow peas, lentils



and pigeon pea, among others, trended lower by an average of 10 per cent during FY26 compared to the previous year, Upadhyay said. **DECLINE IN PRICES** Prices of yellow peas, which hovered around \$380-400 per tonne during 2024-25 were down to around \$320-330 levels during 2025-26. This is despite the government imposing 30 per cent duty on yellow pea imports during the year. Similarly, the pigeon pea prices that hovered around \$1,000-1,100 levels during 2024-25 were down to \$700-850 levels. The same was the case with gram whose prices

ruled at an average of \$650 per tonne during 2024-25 were down to \$470-480 levels and then increased to \$510-520 during 2025-26. **LOWER IMPORTS** “We also imported lower quantities during 2025-26. Volumes of chana were down by about 50 per cent during 2025-26 of 1.4-1.5 mt of what we imported during the previous year. Similarly, the yellow pea volumes were half of what we imported during 2024-25 and the imports of lentils are also down,” Upadhyay said. Rahul Chauhan of IGrain India said except for pigeon peas and black matpe (urad), import volumes of almost all other pulses declined during the year as there were higher stocks brought forward from the previous year. Australia, which shipped record chana quantities to India last year, has seen production rise, but growers are not willing to sell below \$575/tonne. As a result, imports have slowed down, Chauhan said.

NAAS bats for one-time licence for imported horti seeds, hybrids

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The National Academy of Agricultural Sciences (NAAS) has urged the government to introduce a one-time licensing mechanism for globally competitive horticultural varieties and hybrids currently being imported. This, it said, would make them freely accessible to farmers while reducing repeated imports and royalty outgo. In a policy paper released last week, the NAAS called for strengthening domestic breeding programmes in import-dependent crops, such as carrot, beetroot, gherkins, parthenocarpic cucumber, papaya, apple, walnut, hazelnut, kiwifruit, olive, oil palm, date palm, blueberry, tulips and lilium. “Strengthen breeding programmes for crops where seeds and planting materials are heavily imported, and minimise royalty burdens through specific licensing,” the paper, “Horticultural Innovations to Enhance Ex-

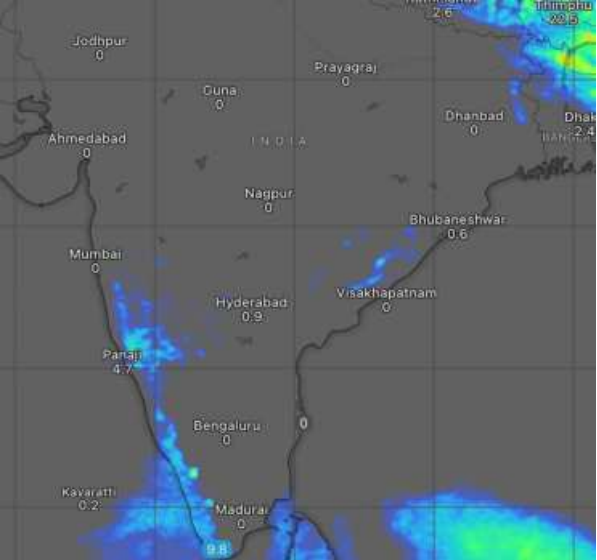


ports from India’, said.

EXPORT FOCUS The NAAS laid stress on developing export-oriented varieties aligned with destination market preferences, nutrition and shelf life. It also called for sustainable, traceable production systems, including wider adoption of Bharat GAP-compliant practices, to improve export readiness. The paper recommended developing protocols for organic and natural farming, strengthening certification, and enhancing traceability across the value chain to ensure food safety.

VALUE-ADDITION To cut logistics costs, the NAAS suggested sea-route protocols for long-duration shipment of fruits such as banana, pomegranate and mango. It also highlighted the need for processing-specific varieties — tomato (paste), onion (flakes/powder), potato (chips, fries), chilli (high oleoresin), turmeric (high curcumin) and marigold (high lutein). The academy further pitched for stronger industry linkages for value-added products across food, pharma and cosmetics, alongside streamlined pesticide regulations through better crop-specific data and alignment with global norms. It also recommended PPP models to support the standardisation of residue limits. Highlighting India’s cost advantage, the NAAS said the country could emerge as a major supplier of hybrid vegetable seeds, especially in solanaceous crops and cucurbits, if the export policies are simplified.

Hot, dry conditions may prevail over N-W, Central India for another week



SOME RESPITE. Kerala, coastal Karnataka, Goa and parts of the North-East may witness thunder showers for the next seven days, while the rest of the country will be hot and humid

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

Global model forecasts indicate that parts of North-West India and Central India will continue to witness heat wave conditions into the next week as a red-hot anti-cyclone pushes dry and hot winds from its base partly over the Arabian Sea and the Mumbai-Konkan coast. The odd thunderstorm may not help much to beat the heat. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said heat wave conditions may prevail over pockets of east Madhya Pradesh, Vidarbha and Chhattisgarh for the next four days, west Madhya Pradesh for three days, and Odisha, Jharkhand, Marathwada, Madhya Maharashtra, north interior Karnataka and Rayalaseema for two days.

ANTI-CYCLONE MOVEMENT This will happen as the heat-engine anti-cyclone moves east from its current base over the north-east Arabian Sea and adjoining Konkan-Mumbai across Peninsular India and sets up its next base over the Bay of Bengal during this week and into the

next, according to the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts. Hot and humid weather conditions may prevail in isolated pockets along the coast over Odisha for the next seven days, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Mahe and coastal Karnataka for five days, coastal Andhra Pradesh and Yanam for the next four days, plains of West Bengal for four days from Sunday, coastal Gujarat for three days, and Konkan and Goa for two days, the IMD update said on Thursday. A heat-building anti-cyclone involves sinking air, where the airmass settles near the surface, raising pressure and creating hot, dry conditions. In contrast, cyclonic systems feature rising air (low pressure), promoting cloud formation, convection and rainfall. For the monsoon to set in, North-West and Central India must heat up during summer to establish strong temperature and pressure gradients with the nearby Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal. Moisture-laden winds then flow along these gradients, bringing rainfall over land.

Buy lead futures and raise stop-loss to ₹195

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

Lead futures have been moving up over the last few sessions. The April contract is now trading at ₹195.

**COMMODITY
CALL.**

After marking a low of ₹192.40 on Friday, the contract has rebounded, indicating that the support at ₹192 is valid. So long as this level holds, the bias will be bullish. From the current level, we anticipate a gradual upswing, which could lift lead futures to ₹203 in the near-term.

NSRCEL, Pernod Ricard Foundation wrap 3rd cohort

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

NSRCEL, the start-up incubator at IIM-Bangalore, in partnership with the Pernod Ricard India Foundation (PRIF), has concluded the third cohort of its Circular Economy Incubation Programme. The programme offered a range of curated interventions, including structured mentoring, industry linkages, grant support, and strategic guidance. **RAPID PROGRESS** These efforts enabled founders to accelerate their journeys from prototype and pilot stages toward early revenue generation and growth



A total of ₹95 lakh in grants was disbursed to 10 start-ups working on climate-smart agriculture, plastic and glass circularity

readiness. A media statement said that a total of ₹95 lakh in grants was disbursed to the cohort of 10 start-ups in tranches. Now in its third consecutive year, the partnership continues to support start-ups working across areas of climate-smart agriculture, plastic circularity and glass circularity.

The programme reflects a shared commitment to fostering scalable, market-ready solutions that address pressing environmental challenges.

STRUCTURED SUPPORT Quoting Anand Sri Ganesh, CEO, NSRCEL, the statement said: “The progress demonstrated by Cohort 3

reflects not only the resilience and ingenuity of the founders but also the importance of structured support in helping start-ups translate circular economy ideas into commercially viable solutions.” Anantika Singh, Senior Director-CSR, Pernod Ricard India, said: “Through our partnership with NSRCEL, we are proud to support entrepreneurs who are building practical, circular solutions to some of today’s most pressing environmental challenges. The progress of this cohort reinforces our commitment to strengthening the circular economy ecosystem in India while creating long-term value for communities and society.”

QUICKLY.

Akasa Air, SpiceJet planes damaged on wing contact



New Delhi: Wings of an Akasa Air and a SpiceJet plane came in contact on the taxiway at the Delhi airport on Thursday afternoon and both aircraft have been grounded due to damages suffered in the incident, according to officials. Akasa Air said in a statement that all passengers and crew were safely disembarked.^{PTI}

Allow search engines access data: EU to Google

Brussels: The European Commission has proposed that Google allow third-party search engines to access its search data, including that of AI chatbots with search functionalities, to comply with the Digital Markets Act. Google, however, said it would fight against the measures, which it said over reached and would jeopardise users' privacy. ^{REUTERS}

Hopes for deal to end Iran conflict rise, but nuclear issues unresolved

PUSH FOR PEACE. Pakistan's Army chief mediates talks in Tehran after previous negotiations were stalled

Reuters
Jerusalem/Washington



KEY NEGOTIATIONS. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi welcomes Pakistan Army chief Asim Munir in Tehran ^{REUTERS}

Optimism grew on Thursday that the Iran war may be near an end, with a key Pakistani mediator having made a breakthrough on “sticky issues”, a source said, although Iran warned the fate of its nuclear programme had not been resolved. The United States and Pakistan have been talking up the prospects for a deal in the more than six-week war, with US President Donald Trump saying the accord would open the crucial Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world's oil and gas supply flows.

OIL PRICE SHOCK
Closure of the strait has triggered the worst oil price shock in history and forced the International Monetary Fund to downgrade its outlook for the global economy, warning prolonged conflict could push the world to the

brink of recession. Pakistan's army chief and a key figure in the mediation, Field Marshal Asim Munir, was in Tehran to try to prevent a renewal of the conflict after marathon talks held in Islamabad last weekend ended without a deal. A senior Iranian official said the trip had led to greater hopes for a second round of talks and an extension of the two-week ceasefire, but said fundamental

differences remain over its nuclear programme. Pakistan's Foreign Ministry said on Thursday that both sides are willing to resume talks, though no date had yet been set. US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth told a Pentagon briefing on Thursday that troops were poised to restart combat operations if a deal was not reached. The issue of a ceasefire in Lebanon, where Israel has

been waging a parallel campaign against Iran-backed militant group Hezbollah, would also be an essential component of any peace talks, Pakistan said. In southern Lebanon, fighting continued to rage on Thursday. A senior Lebanese security official said an Israeli strike had severed the last bridge linking southern Lebanon to the rest of the country. One person was killed in an Israeli strike targeting a car on the road that links to Syria, the country's state news agency said. Meanwhile, Iran's nuclear ambitions were a key sticking point at last weekend's talks. The US proposed a 20-year suspension of all nuclear activity by Iran — an apparent concession from longstanding demands for a permanent ban — while Tehran suggested a halt of three to five years, according to people familiar with the

proposals. Washington has also pressed for any highly enriched uranium to be removed from Iran, while Tehran has demanded that international sanctions against it be lifted. On Thursday, the US widened its blockade on Iranian shipping to include what it called contraband, including weapons, weapons systems, ammunition, nuclear materials, crude and refined oil products as well as iron, steel and aluminium.

10-DAY CEASEFIRE
Israel and Lebanon have agreed to a 10-day ceasefire starting on Thursday, Trump said after speaking to Israeli premier Benjamin Netanyahu and Lebanese counterpart Joseph Aoun. “These two Leaders have agreed that in order to achieve PEACE between their Countries, they will formally begin a 10 Day CEASEFIRE at 5 P.M. EST,” Trump said on his Truth Social network

SC refuses to interfere with HC verdict in Anil Ambani fraud case

The Hindu Bureau
New Delhi



The businessman argued that the signatory to the FAR was not a qualified chartered accountant ^{REUTERS}

The Supreme Court on Thursday found no ground to interfere with a Bombay High Court verdict of February 23 which opened the door wide for fraud classification proceedings to continue against Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) founder Anil Ambani. A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant did not intervene against the Division Bench decision to set aside a Single Judge order of December last year, which had stalled the proceedings. The apex court, however, said observations made by the Division Bench would not affect the merits of the civil suit filed by Ambani challenging the qualifications of the forensic auditor, an entity called BDO India LLP, and its forensic audit report (FAR) of October 2020.

CIVIL SUIT
The businessman has argued that the signatory to the FAR was not a qualified chartered accountant. The top court gave Ambani liberty to pursue any remedy available to him. Senior advocates Kapil

Sibal and Shyam Divan urged the court to record their statement that Ambani, their client, was willing to “sit with the banks and settle”. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the consortium of creditors of public sector banks, said a recording of such a statement by the court would have “repercussions”, especially when separate criminal proceedings were underway in the case. “They (banks) have settled so many accounts with people sitting abroad... You should not be a stumbling block to a settlement,” Sibal submitted. Mehta said such a statement may tend to influence other courts and fora.

TCS allows work from home in Nashik office; NCW starts probe

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) has allowed voluntary work from home for its Nashik employees following protest marches in the city condemning allegations of sexual assault and coercion cases. Simultaneously, the National Commission for Women (NCW) has constituted a fact-finding committee to look into the allegations. Around 300-400 women marched from the TCS' Nashik office towards the Collector's office on

Thursday afternoon and submitted a letter condemning the alleged crimes against the seven accused in the nine FIRs. Local police deployed in the area said the march was peaceful and ended without incident. Meanwhile, TCS gave employees the alternative to work from home following reports of sloganeering outside TCS office. **NCW TO INVESTIGATE** A four-member fact-finding committee set up by the NCW is also set to visit TCS office on April 17, Friday and draft a report under the di-

rections of the commission. The Committee, comprising Justice Sadhna Jadhav, retired judge of the Bombay High Court, BK Sinha, former DGP of Haryana, Monika Arora, Supreme Court advocate, and Lilabati, Senior Coordinator, NCW, will be submitting the report within 10 working days. This report will be based on an on-the-spot inquiry at the TCS facility in Nashik as well as other relevant locations, examine the circumstances leading to the incident and assess the response by authorities. Further, members will interact with victims, police of-



ficials, company representatives, and other relevant stakeholders, identify lapses, if any, and recommend appropriate action against those found responsible. It will also suggest remedial measures to prevent recur-

rence of such incidents. **COORDINATED PROBE** This investigation will run alongside a company investigation declared by Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran and led by Aarthi Subramanian, Chief Operating Officer at TCS. Currently, a 12-member SIT under an ACP-rank officer is probing the matter, while coordinating with the Intelligence Bureau, Anti-Terrorism Squad and National Investigation Agency. Earlier, IT representative body NASSCOM said the technology industry operates under strict governance frameworks and unequivocal standards for employee safety, and workplace conduct. It stated that any instance of misconduct or harassment “is isolated in nature and does not reflect systemic pattern within the industry.” Last week, the Nagpur police had arrested seven individuals Tausif Attar, Danish Sheikh, Shahrukh Qureshi, Raza Memon, Ashwini Chainani, Shafi Sheikh and Asif Ansari. Another accused Nida Khan is absconding. The police received nine FIRs from women employees alleging accusations from July 2022 to March 2026.

Novo Nordisk recruits 2,000 in 2026 to reshape workforce

Bloomberg

Novo Nordisk has hired about 2,000 people this year, reshaping its workforce after laying off about 10 per cent of staff in 2025. The figure reflects successful job offers, and about 1,400 of those workers have already started, a company spokeswoman said.

Novo ended last year with about 7,800 fewer employees as CEO Mike Doustdar pushed through the company's biggest-ever layoffs to make the organisation faster and more aggressive. The company has lost its lead in the obesity market and is counting on a new pill to keep up. It had a turnover rate of about 18 per cent last year.



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Chennai: MG Chennai Ambattur (08037080866), MG Chennai Anna Salai (08037080865), MG Chennai Mount Road (08037080906), MG Chennai OMR (08037080862), MG Chennai Chrompet (08037080867), MG Chennai Poonamallee (08037080907) **Coimbatore:** MG Coimbatore Avinashi Road (08037080888), MG Coimbatore Mettupalayam Road (08037080903) **Tirupati:** MG Tirupati (08037080879)

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